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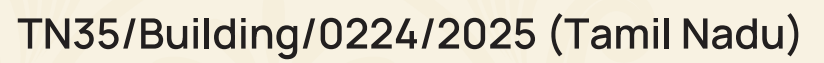
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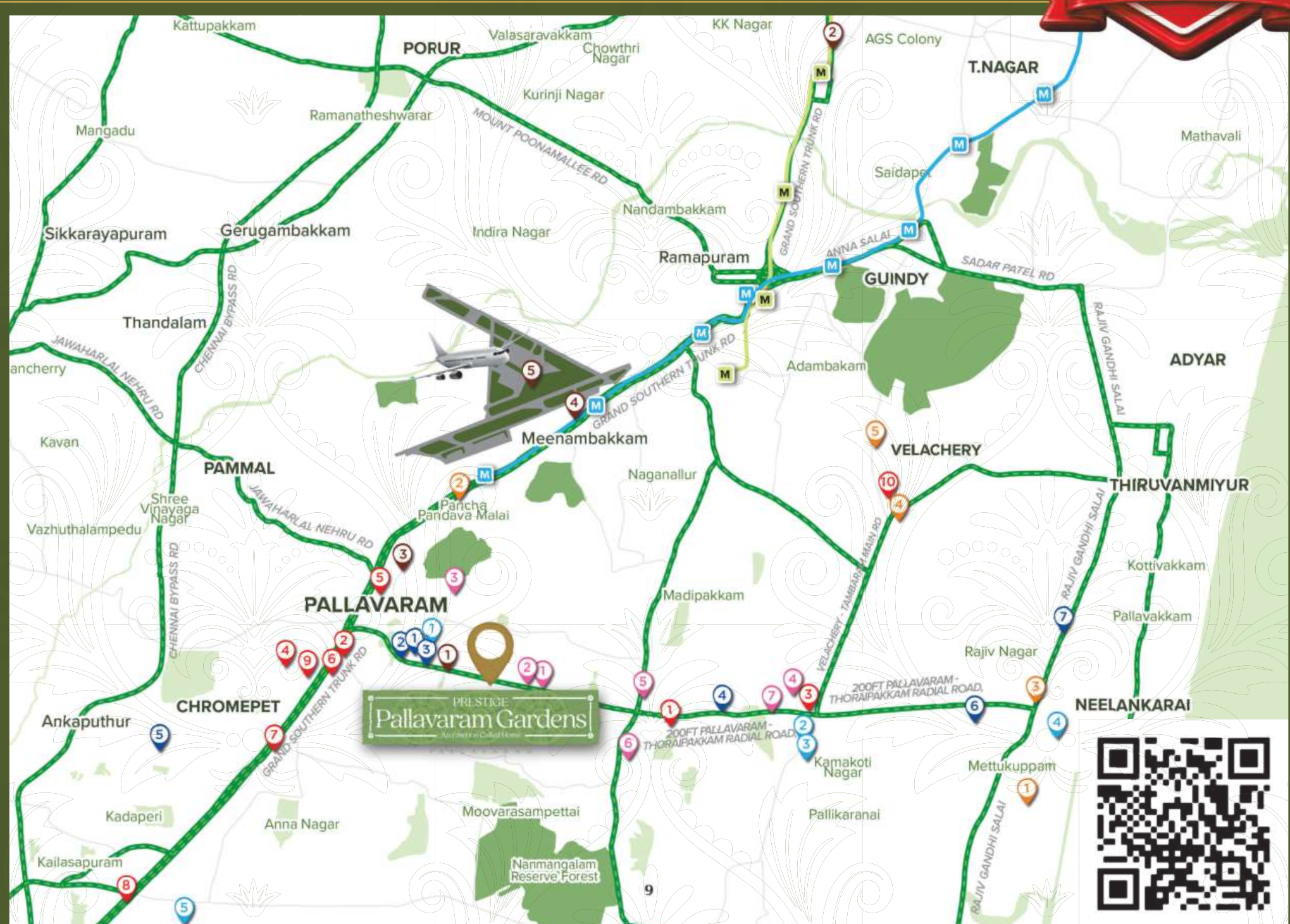
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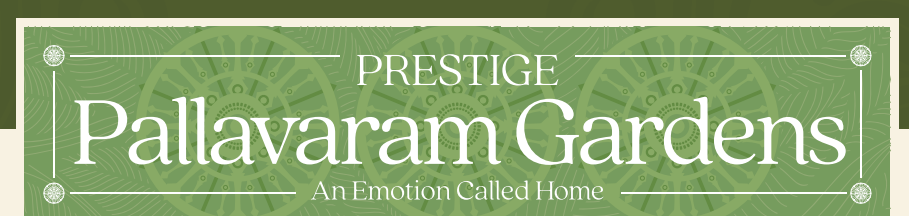
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BORDER EXPOSURE

'Global opium trade shift felt in the east'

NEWS » PAGE 10

FIFA WORLD CUP

Ecuador stuns Germany, enters the round of 32

SPORT » PAGE 15





THREE-LANGUAGE POLICY

Classes 7, 8, 9 can stay with old combo: CBSE

NEWS » PAGE 10

LUCKNOW FIRE

The rules that failed lives

The death of 15 in U.P. points to regulatory gaps amid rapid urbanisation

GROUND ZERO » PAGE 9



STRAIT STATUS

Iran reasserts right to control shipping

WORLD » PAGE 14

NEARBY



CM takes part in drug abuse awareness run

CHENNAI

The Tiruvallur district police have arrested the agent who brought workers from Odisha to the sea food processing unit where an ammonia leak has so far claimed 15 lives. » PAGE 6

Ammonia gas leak toll goes up to 15; labour agent held

CHENNAI

The Tiruvallur district police have arrested the agent who brought workers from Odisha to the sea food processing unit where an ammonia leak has so far claimed 15 lives. » PAGE 6

METROPLUS WEEKEND » 6 PAGES
PROPERTY PLUS » 22 PAGES
IN TWO SECTIONS

Ayodhya fund case: all eight accused in judicial custody

Around ₹80 lakh recovered from those arrested, says prosecution officer; close aides of the Ram Temple Trust chief, Champat Rai, among those held; VHP denies reports of the chief resigning

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The eight people named as the accused in a first information report (FIR) regarding the alleged embezzlement of donations received at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya have been arrested and sent to judicial custody until Monday.

"The eight accused will be produced before the Special Court dealing with corruption-related matters on Monday. A total of ₹79.85 lakh has been recovered from them," prosecution officer K.C. Verma told journalists outside the court in Ayodhya on Friday, where heavy police security was deployed.

The accused include close aides of Champat Rai, general secretary of the

Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, who is said to have resigned from the post. However, the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) social media head, Rakesh Pandey, denied such reports as fake news.

The accused – Lavkush Mishra, Anukalp Mishra, Manish Yadav, Ramashankar Yadav alias Tinnu, Subhash Srivastava, Avinash Shukla, Rama Shankar Mishra, and Karunesh Pandey – have been booked on charges including theft, criminal breach of trust, cheating, and criminal conspiracy. "At the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, devotees deposited money in the donation boxes. The money was allegedly stolen by employees of the trust," the prosecution officer said. As per the FIR, the accused were responsible for counting the cash and valuables donated by devotees at the temple.

Cong. demands SC-monitored investigation

NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday demanded a Supreme Court-monitored investigation into the allegations of the embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and called for immediate disbandment of the current temple trust. » PAGE 11

Continued on » PAGE 10
AT THE CENTRE OF THE ROW » PAGE 11



Champat Rai, chief of the temple trust, during the construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya in January 2023. SANDEEP SAXENA

Govt. releases names of 6 personnel killed in Operation Sindoor

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

In the first official disclosure of military casualties from Operation Sindoor, the Centre on Friday published the names of six armed forces personnel who laid down their lives during the cross-border operation in May 2025.

The names of the six personnel, five from the Indian Army and one from the Indian Air Force, have been included in the Roll of Honour on the National War Memorial website.

The fallen personnel are: Subedar Major Pawan Kumar of Headquarters 10 Infantry Brigade; Rifleman Sunil Kumar, Vir Chakra, of 4 Jammu and Kashmir Light Infantry; Lance Naik Dinesh Kumar of 5 Field Regiment; Agniveer Mood Muralinaik of 851 Light Regiment; Havildar Sunil Kumar Singh of 237 Field Workshop Company; and

Fallen heroes

The six personnel who laid down their lives during the cross-border operation in May 2025:

- Subedar Major Pawan Kumar
- Rifleman Sunil Kumar, Vir Chakra
- Lance Naik Dinesh Kumar
- Agniveer Mood Muralinaik
- Havildar Sunil Kumar Singh
- Sergeant Surendra Kumar, Vayu Sena Medal

Sergeant Surendra Kumar, Vayu Medal, of 39 Wing.

The names of the six men were released with the annual list of troops killed during various military operations in 2025. Their names will be inscribed on the Tyag Chakra (Circle of Sacrifice) at the National War Memorial in New Delhi.

CONG. SLAMS DELAY » PAGE 11

MDMK's general body to decide on alliance today

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With speculation rife that the Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK) will join the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK)-led alliance, MDMK chief Vaiko on Friday convened the party's high-level committee to decide on switching alliances.

The final announcement on moving away from the DMK-led front will be made on Saturday after a meeting of the MDMK general body in Chennai.

There are expectations that the MDMK may ask its two MLAs – T.M. Rajendran (Kadayanallur) and Senthil Selvan (Sirkazhi) – to resign from the membership of the Assembly as they had contested on the DMK's 'Rising Sun' symbol in the 2026 election. But Mr. Senthil Selvan has reportedly decided to stay on as an MLA.

INTERNATIONAL MSME DAY
27th June, 2026



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Did my ambition write cheques my abilities can't cash?
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is actually just delusion feeding my risk appetite?

Every mind that has birthed a business
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Because when you are all in...

'failure is not an option.'

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INBRIEF



Passengers escape unhurt after omni bus catches fire

Panic gripped the passengers of an omni bus heading from Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh to Puducherry after the vehicle caught fire near Sholavaram early on Friday. The private bus was approaching Sholavaram around 6 a.m. when the driver Sundar noticed sparks emerging from the vehicle. All 36 passengers escaped unhurt as the driver promptly evacuated them from the bus. However, all their belongings were destroyed in the fire. Firefighters from the Red Hills and Ambattur fire stations rushed to the scene and brought the blaze under control. A probe into the cause of the fire is under way.



‘Pink room’ opened for girls at Avadi Corporation school

A ‘pink room’ was opened at the Avadi Corporation Higher Secondary School in Thirumullaivoyal to provide a safe space for girls to rest during menstruation. The room has facilities including a bed, a hot bag, a napkin vending machine, indoor games, and an attached washroom. A ‘pink teacher’ has also been appointed to provide guidance to students. The initiative by Aahwahan Foundation, in collaboration with NTT DATA, aims to support girls as many are forced to stay home because of menstrual pain and the absence of private spaces to rest. Braja Kishore Pradhan, CEO and founder of Aahwahan Foundation, said, “Our mission is to ensure that no girl is forced to miss school because of a natural biological process.”

WRD plans community-led effort to rejuvenate upper reaches of Cooum river

The department will soon invite various stakeholders to adopt stretches of the river and assist in restoration and maintenance; officials held a joint inspection recently with various stakeholders

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

In a move to strengthen river restoration efforts, the Water Resources Department (WRD) plans to involve local communities and non-governmental organisations in the rejuvenation of Cooum river.

It will soon invite Expressions of Interest from various stakeholders to adopt stretches of the waterway and assist the department in restoring and maintaining it. The department has begun seeking suggestions through consultations with different stakeholders on the rejuvenation of the Cooum.

While multiple attempts have been made to rejuvenate the river through the coordination of various government agencies, the department is now aiming for a more comprehensive effort with public participation.

As the first step, a team of senior WRD officials held a joint inspection recently with various stakeholders, including representatives from voluntary organisations, Anna University and Seneerkupam residents.

The team inspected the nearly 3.8-km stretch between Paruthipattu and Kannadapalayam check dams, which is proposed to be taken up as a pilot



Pressing problem: Despite multiple attempts at rejuvenation, solid waste and sewage pollution continue to affect the nearly 40 km-long upper reaches of the Cooum river. FILE PHOTO

The Water Resources Department is now aiming for a more comprehensive effort to rejuvenate the river with public participation

project. WRD officials said the involvement of civic associations and voluntary organisations would help improve monitoring of the river.

While some of the improvements have been carried out in city limits under Chennai Rivers Restoration Trust, efforts now focus on rejuvenating the upper reaches till Tiruvallur, which too are facing pollution. Solid waste manage-

ment and sewage pollution are major challenges in the nearly 40 km-long upper reaches of the Cooum river as well.

The department has received suggestions to allot specific reaches to each organisation for cleaning, plantation and maintenance, officials said.

Plans are on to partner with voluntary organisations to construct modular sewage treatment plants to intercept and divert raw sewage that otherwise joins the river.

The WRD had recently coordinated with voluntary organisations for the construction of modular STP project along a portion of Adyar river.

Exnora International

has come forward to clean the nearly three km of the river stretch between Koyambedu and Nerkundram.

V. Subramani of Exnora International, said the efforts aim to restore the river through community participation. “We have suggested taking up the stretch between Koyambedu and Nerkundram for water hyacinth removal and plantation along the banks. We suggested river-front development and walkways to encourage public use and prevent dumping of garbage and sewage pollution,” he said.

The pilot project would be expanded to other stretches based on its outcome.

Expert says early diagnosis of scoliosis improves long-term health outcomes

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Early diagnosis and timely treatment can prevent scoliosis from progressing and improve long-term outcomes, particularly among children and adolescents, said Charanjit Singh Dhillon, Director, MIOT Centre for Spine Surgery, MIOT International.

Speaking at a webinar on Friday, marking Scoliosis Awareness Day, Dr. Dhillon said the condition, characterised by an abnormal curvature of the spine, often develops without obvious symptoms in its early stages, making regular screening and early medical evaluation crucial.

The webinar, on ‘Understanding Scoliosis: Early Detection, Modern Treatment, and Better Outcomes’, was presented by MIOT International as part of The Hindu Wellness Series. Dr. Dhillon said scoliosis can also affect adults. While some cases require only observation, others may progress and need bracing or surgery. Early identification helps in preventing severe spinal deformity and reducing the need for complex treatment.

He discussed the common signs of scoliosis, the importance of early screening, and the diagnostic process, highlighting how clinical evaluation and imaging help determine the severity of the



spinal curvature and guide treatment decisions.

Treatment advances

Dr. Dhillon said treatment depends on factors such as the patient’s age, the degree of spinal curvature, and the likelihood of progression.

Advances in spine surgery, including minimally invasive techniques and improved deformity correction procedures, have significantly enhanced patient outcomes, he said.

During the interactive session, Dr. Dhillon addressed questions from participants on identifying scoliosis in children, sports participation, pregnancy, recovery after surgery, and managing scoliosis in adulthood. He urged parents to seek medical evaluation if they notice uneven shoulders, an asymmetrical waist, or other signs suggestive of spinal curvature, noting that timely diagnosis remains the key to successful treatment.

The session was moderated by Athira Elssa Johnson, Senior Reporter, The Hindu. The webinar can be viewed here: <https://newsth.live/THMIOTY>

THE HINDU
Air Surcharge as applicable:
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Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM OF E-TENDER NOTICE
Chief Project Manager, Gati Shakti, N.W.Rly, Bikaner for and on behalf of President of India invites open E-Tender for the following works up to 15:00 Hrs on 10.07.2026 as below:-
Tender No.: 06-2026-GSU-BKN.
Name of Work with its Location: Civil work in C/W of Augmentation Coaching Maintenance Facilities at Lalgahr (Phase-II).
Earlier Approx. Cost of Work: Rs. 948267738.01.
Modified Approx Cost of Work: Rs. 947701670.91.
Earlier Bid Security Amount (in Rs.): Rs. 18965400.00.
Modified Bid Security Amount (in Rs.): Rs. 18954000.00.
Date and Time for submission of tender & opening of tender: Bidding start date on 26.06.2026 & Tender closing Date & time up to 15:00 Hrs on 10.07.2026.
Note- Other terms & conditions will be shown on the website www.ireps.gov.in.
Dy.Chief Engineer/Gati Shakti Bikaner
922-PS/26

AUGMENTATION OF INSTALLED AUTOMATIC FIRE ALARM AND DETECTION SYSTEM
Tender No. SNT-14-LMG-2026-27
Dated: 24-06-2026. Works tenders through “E” Tendering system for and on behalf of the president of India are invited for the works as detailed below:-
Name of work: Augmentation of Installed Automatic Fire Alarm and Detection System of make Ravel & Nofire of Lumding Division.
Tender Value: ₹2,47,22,874.31/-.
Earnest Money: ₹4,94,500/-.
Date & time of Closing of tender: At 15.00 hrs. & opening at 15.30 hrs. on 16-07-2026.
The complete information with tender documents of above e-tender will be available in the website www.ireps.gov.in
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CORRIGENDUM NO. 02 AGAINST TENDER NOTICE NO. CON/2026/APR/04 DATED: 30-04-2026
Corrigendum- 02 for Tender No. **CE-CON-FT-EPC-2026-05** has been published. For details please visit www.ireps.gov.in
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OPEN E-TENDER
No. COS/CRJ/PUB/e-Tender/19/0162.
Date: 24/06/2026. The following e-Tenders can be accessed under the link www.ireps.gov.in. Offers for such e-Tender can be submitted only electronically by accessing the link www.ireps.gov.in → login → E-Tender Stores/Supply.
Vendors may also contact the following officials to obtain clarification regarding tender or IREPS related information if any.
Dy. CMM/M-II/CLW/Chittaranjan. 9163340708 or AMM/M. 9163340706.
Office Address: Office of the PCMM/CLW/Chittaranjan. SL No.: (1).
Tender No.: 75264135. Brief Description of Item: Sand Box Assembly, As Per Drg. No.1209-01.138-031 ALT-10. [Warranty Period: 30 Months after the date of delivery].
Quantity: 7457.00 Nos.
Earnest Money Deposit (Rupees): ₹622810.00.
Tender Closing Date & Time (IST): 20/07/2026 at 11:00 AM.
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EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
No. DNR/S&T/Tele/2026/3 Danapur, Dtd. 22.06.2026
Divisional Railway Manager (Signal & Tele), East Central Railway, Danapur Division, for and on behalf of President of India invites tenders on web portal www.ireps.gov.in for the following work:-
1. Name of work with its location: Provision of CCTV Cameras in C&W Depot Premises of DNR Division.
2. Approximate cost of work: Rs.21358870.89.
3. Earnest Money: Rs. 427200.00.
4. Last Date & Time of Submission: Up to 15.00 hrs. on 15.07.2026.
5. Opening of tender: 15.00 hrs. on 15.07.2026.
6. Website Particulars where detail of the work and criteria can be seen: www.ireps.gov.in.
7. Address of the office from where detail information can be obtained: Sr. Divl. Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, East Central Railway, Danapur
Note: Any Corrigendum if required will be uploaded on above website before 14 days.
East Signal & Telecom Engineer
East Central Railway, Danapur
PR/0453/DNR/S&T/T/26-27/32

SOUTHERN RAILWAY					
Tiruchchirappalli Division					
E Tender Notice No. TPJ/11 of 2026 Dated: 23.06.2026					
For and on behalf of the President of India, The Divisional Railway Manager / Works Branch / Tiruchchirappalli Division, Tiruchchirappalli-1, invites ONLINE tenders for the following works as per tender notice and Complete details are given in our e-tender portal www.ireps.gov.in .					
Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of the Works	Approx. value of the work (₹ in Lakhs)	Amount of EMD (in ₹)	Completion period of Work
1	TPJ-11-2026-01	Deep Screening for a length of 101.419 km on main Lines & 32.829 km on loop lines at various locations by BCM in Sr.DEN/East/TPJ jurisdiction.	453.15	906300	12 months
2	TPJ-11-2026-02	Deep Screening for a length of 27.048 km on main Lines & 3.05 km on loop lines at various locations by BCM in Sr.DEN/North/TPJ and DEN/Central/TPJ jurisdictions.	100.62	201200	9 months
3	TPJ-11-2026-03	Through Formation Treatment and Rehabilitation for a length of 7.80 Km at various locations between NMJ and KIK stations in SSE/P.way/A-TVR section.	1275.37	2550700	12 months
4	TPJ-11-2026-04	Improvements of Intensive care unit, Auditorium complex and construction of annex building in RH/GOC.	213.62	427300	9 months
5	TPJ-11-2026-05	Through Weld Renewal by Mobile Flash butt welding plant at various locations for a total length of 30.80 km in VM- KPD section.	499.76	999500	12 months
6	TPJ-11-2026-06	(i) Brightening up of staff quarters at various locations in SSE/Works/TJ section and (ii) Improvements to side drains at NGT station yard.	129.48	259000	6 months
7	TPJ-11-2026-07	SRPM Head works - Operation and maintenance of chlorination plant, summer watering arrangements and arresting pipe leakage en-route at SRPM water works in SSE/W/B/GOC section for a period of one year.	51.37	102700	12 months
8	TPJ-11-2026-08	Pumping out of rain water / seepage water including Desilting and removal of bushes / debris for a period of one year in ADEN / TVR SB division.	141.10	282200	12 months
9	TPJ-11-2026-09	VM-TPJ (Chord line) section - Improvements to drainage arrangements to the existing subways in SSE/W/VRI & LLI section and Water level monitoring of subway no.184B in ADEN/North/TPJ section.	694.90	1389800	6 months
10	TPJ-11-2026-10	VM-KPD and VM-PDY Section - Improvements to drainage arrangements to the existing subways and provision of side drain to the existing subways in SSE/Works/VM section.	534.70	1069500	6 months

Sl.No. 1 - 5 : Tender closing date and time: 20.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
Sl.No. 6 - 10 : Tender closing date and time: 23.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
Maintenance Period / Defect Liability Period:
Sl. No. 1 & 2 : 3 months; Sl. No. 3 : 6 months or one monsoon, whichever is later; Sl. No. 4: 3 year; Sl. No. 5 : 12 months; Sl. No. 6 : 3 months; Sl. No. 7 & 8 : Nil; Sl. No. 9 & 10 : 4 years
Note: (i) It is the responsibility of the tenderer to check any Corrigendum issued for any correction or modifications uploaded subsequently in website, the same shall be taken into account while submitting tender.
(ii) Exemption from remitting Bid Security Amount (EMD): The following categories of tenderers are only exempted from remitting Bid Security:
(a) Any firm recognized by Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion (DIPP) as ‘Startups’ shall be exempted from payment of bid Security.
(b) Labour Co-operative Societies shall submit only 50% of Bid Security.
Tenderer should submit relevant documents along with his / their offer from remitting Bid Security. Non-submission of relevant documents, shall lead to summary rejection of offer.
Corrigendum to E-Tender Notice No. TPJ/10 of 2026 Dated: 09.06.2026
(i) Modified tender value & EMD amount:

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Value of the work (₹ in Lakhs)	Amount of EMD (in ₹)		
		Existing	Read as	Existing	Read as
1	TPJ-10-2026-03	666.06	664.28	1332100	1328600

The other terms and conditions remain unchanged.

E Tender Notice No. TPJ/12 of 2026 Dated: 23.06.2026					
For and on behalf of the President of India, The Divisional Railway Manager / Works Branch / Tiruchchirappalli Division, Tiruchchirappalli-1, invites ONLINE tenders for the following works as per tender notice and Complete details are given in our e-tender portal www.ireps.gov.in .					
Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of the Works	Approx. value of the work (₹ in Lakhs)	Amount of EMD (in ₹)	Completion period of Work
1	TPJ-12-2026-01	Supply, Installation, Commissioning, and 5-Year Operation & Maintenance of 28 Nos. of Track - Based Electronic Rail Lubricators in Sr.DEN/East/TPJ jurisdiction. (Service contract)	426.49	363300	60 months

Sl.No. 1 : Tender closing date and time: 21.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
Note: Tenderer should submit relevant document along with his/their offer from remitting Bid Security. Non-submission of relevant documents, shall lead to summary rejection of offer.
Divisional Railway Manager / Works / Tiruchchirappalli

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SOUTHERN RAILWAY
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The Southern Railway, Railway Higher Secondary School, invites applications from qualified educators to join RAILWAY HIGHER SECONDARY SCHOOL (CBSE), PERAMBUR, CHENNAI - 600 011 on a contractual basis for the academic year 2026-2027
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Sr. Divisional Personnel Officer
Chennai Division / Souther Railway

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE FOR ENGINEERING WORK
E-Tender Notice No: 52-Mech-BSP-Rake-Exam, Date: 16.06.2026.
Name of Work: Outsourcing of "Assistance in end to end (Intensive) examination, repair activity and Other allied activities" over Bilaspur division for a period of two years on open tender basis.
Tender Value: ₹ 04,59,22,046.36 (₹ Four Crore Fifty Nine Lakh Twenty Two Thousand Forty Six And Thirty Six Paise Only) (Inclusive of all expenditure and GST).
Earnest Money Deposit: ₹ 03,79,600/- (₹ Three Lakh Seventy Nine Thousand And Six Hundred Only).
Opening of Tender: 12:00 Hours On 09.07.2026.
Further all details are available on Railway's website www.ireps.gov.in. Except E-tender no other mode of submission of tender will be accepted.
Sr. Divt. Mech. Engineer (Frt) CPRI/10/PH/228 Bilaspur.
f South East Central Railway % @seccrall

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS
MUSIC DANCE DRAMA
The Music Academy Madras
Today from 10.00 a.m. to 12 Noon at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall – Violin Centric Workshop – Mula Abhyasa at Music Academy – Violin Fundamentals and Practice Techniques – by Embur S Kannan – Registration – Rs.50/-, Students and Rasikas welcome. Contact: Music Academy Office – 28112231 / 28115162. Programme under the endowment instituted by the family of Sri. Dwaram in memory of Sangita Kalanidhi Sri. Dwaram Venkataswamy Naidu.
Arulmigu Sri Kapaleeswarar Temple, Mylapore, Chennai.
Today - 27.06.2026 - Saturday - 6.45 P.M - Pradosham Special Program -NAMASANKER-THANAM by Isai Peroli Dr. R. Ganesh & Party ALL ARE WELCOME.
Hamsadhvani 97909 09567
TODAY 6.30 p.m.: "KSHETRA MAHIMA - NAGARESHU KAN-BHI" Musical discourse by B.SUCHITRA (Yuva Puraskar Awardee 2025) with Shri Venkateswaram Harmonium, M. S.Venkatasubramaniam - Mridanganam at Youth Hostel, 2nd Avenue, Indira Nagar, Adyar. All are welcome.
Mathangi, 24992672
Today 4 p.m Mukund Bharadwaj & Party, 6pm Dr Brindha Manickavasakan & Party. Ragasudha Hall.
PERAMBUR Sangeetha Sabha (Est 1951)
Carnatic Vocal Concert Today 6.30pm. Amritha Murali - Vocal, L Ramakrishnan - Violin & N C Bharadwaj - Mridangam. Venue: Sri Ranga Hall, Kaligi Rangathanam Montford School, Patel Road, Perambur, Chennai-11. All are invited.
Pushpanjali Cultural Trust
Today 4 p.m at R.K Swamy auditorium Mylapore Bharathanatam by Kum ASHMITHA (Dis of Smt Nithya Sripathy) 5.30 p.m Bharathanatam by Kum. SWETHA KANNAN (Dis of Dr Sreelatha Vinod) 7 p.m. Bharathanatam by Kum R SAIRITHIKA & Kum. R. SAIS-AMYUKTHA (Dis of Dr. D. Bhavani)
MISCELLANEOUS
Tattvaloka Auditorium, 76 Eldams Road, Teynampet, Chennai 18. Tel: 24328124 / 25 Mobile: 9042765660
Ancient Temples of Tamil Nadu an illustrated lecture by Dr. Chithra Madhavan (Historian) Today, 6:00 pm. All are welcome.

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PERSONAL CHANGE OF NAME
PERSONAL CHANGE OF NAME
I, Rajesh Kumar Chordia, father of Mehak Jain, Residing at Old # 47, New #120, Appu Street, Mylapore, Chennai 600004, declare that my Minor daughter's name appears as 'Mehak Jain Rajesh Kumar Chordia' in Passport No. V1421631. Both names refer to the same person for all purposes and reasons.
I, BHUVANESWARI S. d/o. Sivarajan S. P. Wife of Anand S., DOB 10-07-1978, residing at Nimniyas, Plot No. 28, Door No. 17, 2nd Main Road, Iyyappa Nagar, Rajakilpakkam, Selayur, Chennai - 600073, shall henceforth be known as Bhuvanewari A for all future purposes vide notary affidavit ES591005 of 25.06.2026 - Bhuvanewari S
I, SHABANA Tabasum B, D/o Syed Bashu, aged 49 years, residing at 5/3, S1, Iyam Perumal Street, Royapettah, Chennai - 600014, Tamil Nadu, hereby declare that the names "Shabana Tabasum B" and "Shabana Tabasum Syed Bashu" refer to one and the same person, as affirmed in my affidavit dated 25.06.2026 at Chennai.
MY DAUGHTER, Saraswathi K, daughter of Thiru Kaliyamoorthi, born on 28th September 2009, at Villupuram District and residing at No.23, Velu Naicker Street, Sholinganallur, Chennai-600 119, shall henceforth be Known as Vaishnavi K Kalaimani.K (Mother)
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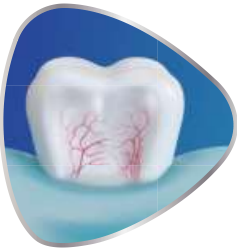


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Pulse polio immunisation campaign tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A national pulse polio immunisation campaign will be held across Tamil Nadu on June 28.

Elaborate arrangements have been made to immunise a total of 52.91 lakh children, aged 0 to five, through 43,051 centres set up in all Primary Health Centres, government hospitals, anganwadi centres, schools, and other places in the State.

According to a press release, even if children aged 0 to five had already received the oral polio vaccine as per the national immunisation schedule, they should be given the drops again on the day of the immunisation camp.

The centres will function from 7 a.m. to 5 p.m. On the first day (Sunday), the drops will be administered at both booths. On June 29 and 30, it will be administered at transit booths. It will also be administered to children of migrant workers.

☀️🌙	Timings
CHENNAI	
SATURDAY, JUN. 27	
☀️	RISE 05:46 SET 18:39
🌙	RISE 16:36 SET 03:17
SUNDAY, JUN. 28	
☀️	RISE 05:46 SET 18:39
🌙	RISE 17:29 SET 04:04
MONDAY, JUN. 29	
☀️	RISE 05:46 SET 18:39
🌙	RISE 18:19 SET 04:54

Centre for autism sees 1,050 registrations in 18 months

Over 700 are benefitting from regular therapy sessions. At present, it sees nearly 100 persons daily, including eight to 10 new patients, says deputy chief executive officer Rema Chandramohan

Serena Josephine M.
CHENNAI

The Centre of Excellence for Persons with Autism has crossed 1,000 enrolments in 18 months of its launch, with a total of 1,050 children registered so far. It is now scaling up its services for persons with autism by planning to add physical education, pre-vocational training for children under 18, vocational training for adults and new infrastructure, including a swimming pool for hydrotherapy and a sensory park.

The centre, which was established on December 5, 2024 on the campus of the Government Institute of Rehabilitation Medicine, K.K. Nagar sees nearly 100 persons daily, with eight to 10 new patients every day, according to Rema Chandramohan, deputy chief executive officer, Centre of Excellence (CoE) for Persons with Autism. The centre receives persons from across the State. A few persons who had travelled from countries such as Canada and the Middle East for vacation had also approached the centre, Dr. Chandramohan added.

In the initial month, the CoE saw five to 10 patients but awareness through word of mouth had driven



Enhanced care: The centre, established in 2024 in K.K. Nagar, receives persons from across the State for treatment.

steady growth. “We now have nearly 1,050 enrolled children. Of this, more than 700 are benefitting from regular therapy sessions at the CoE,” she said. The centre was initially supported by the National Health Mission, Tamil Nadu.

The team includes paediatricians, psychiatrists, clinical psychologists, occupational therapists, speech therapists, special educators, and physiotherapists. A paediatrician, first, screens the child using the Modified Checklist for Autism in Toddlers, a screening mandatorily done in Western countries

when a child is brought for immunisation at 18 months. “This is when the signs can be picked up. Not responding to name calling, poor communication and poor social skills are the three main signs of autism,” Dr. Chandramohan said.

A psychiatrist and a psychologist evaluate the child further, with the latter confirming the diagnosis using the Indian Scale for Assessment of Autism and Childhood Autism Rating Scale-2. The child then goes to each of the therapists. They identify the developmental gaps, set individualised goals, and begin

training focussed on daily living skills.

Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) might come with certain comorbidities for which the children need to be treated. “ASD with ADHD ranges between 30 per cent and 70 per cent in different studies, while other comorbidities include depression, anxiety, and sleeplessness. Medications are prescribed for these conditions,” Dr. Chandramohan said.

Daycare centre “We have a daycare centre being run along with an NGO (Madhuram Narayanan Centre for Exceptional Children) where 25 children aged 1.5 to eight years are enrolled. Special educators train children in skills - 200 skills for children under three and 600 skills for those aged three to eight. These include eating independently, buttoning clothes, and writing,” she said.

The centre is developing a mobile application for therapists and parents. This will allow them to track therapy sessions and goals.

Soon, pre-vocational training, including in block printing and fireless cooking for children under 18 and vocational training for adults will be introduced.

Youth held for allegedly raping girl

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The All Women Police on Friday arrested a youth for allegedly raping a 17-year-old girl and launched an investigation to nab two

more persons who allegedly raped her.

An investigation revealed that she and her friend were acquainted with a couple of youths over social media. One of them invited her and her

friend to his house on the pretext that he was unwell. The accused, later, took her to a vacant land near Gerugambakkam and called his friends. She alleged that all of them committed the sexual assault.



GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU

DIRECTORATE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION AND RESEARCH, KILPAUK, CHENNAI - 10.

NOTIFICATION

Online filled-in applications are invited for admission to the following Course for 2026-2027 Session

Government Seats:

> Diploma in Dental Mechanic, Diploma in Dental Hygienist, Allied and Healthcare Diploma and Certificate Courses

Government Seats and Government Quota Seats in Self-Financing colleges:

> Diploma in Medical Laboratory Science

For prospectus and filling up of applications kindly visit the following website. www.tnmedicalselection.org

Date of Commencement for Registration of online application	27.06.2026 @ 12.01 PM
Last date for Registration of online application	15.07.2026 upto 5.00 PM

DIPR / 570/ DISPALY / 2026 DIRECTOR OF MEDICAL EDUCATION AND RESEARCH



BENGALURU NORTH CITY CORPORATION

Office of the Executive Engineer, Sarvajnanagara Division, 9th C Main, HRBR Layout, 1st Block. Kalyannagara Bengaluru - 560 043

No:EE/SGN/KPPP/TEND/04/2026-27Date: 25-06-2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (TWO COVER SYSTEM)

(Through GOK KPP Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> only)

The Executive Engineer (Sarvajnanagara Division), BNCC Zone-1, Bengaluru, on behalf of the Commissioner, BNCC invites tenders from eligible Contractors registered in Greater Bengaluru Authority or equivalent registration with CPWD/KPWD /Railways/MES/ National Highway or any State Government Organizations. For the construction of works detailed in the table below.

Sl No.	Name of the works
1.	(PACKAGE-01) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in 8th Main, HRBR Layout, 1st Block and approach Roads 6th Cross Maruthi Layout, 1st Cross and Cross Roads of Prakruthi Layout, 3rd, 4th, 9th and 10th Cross Telecom Layout, Chikkanna Layout Cross Roads, Byraweshwara Layout 2A, 2nd Main Road Secondary drain at Nagawara Village, Matkar Main Road 1st to 6th Cross, 2nd & 3rd Block HBR Layout, 1st A Main Road and Cemity Road, 16th to 21st Cross Roads, Yaseen Nagar 10th Cross Roads, Brindavana Nagar, Yaseen Nagar, SWD Service Road Hennur Main Road, Shanimahatma Temple 4th Cross Roads, 3rd Cross, 1st A, 1st B, Cross Roads, 10th Main 7th Main Road HBR Layout 4th Block HBR Layout, 9th Main Road 10th, 11th Cross Roads 4th Block HBR Layout, from 6th, 7th, 8th Cross Roads 4th Block HBR Layout, Budda Shaila Layout Cross Road and Sub Cross Roads Near Ashok Legends Apartments of Ward No 32 Banasawadi & 31 Kalyana Nagara , 23 Hennur, 24 HBR Layout (Anubanda-04, GO No:38,40,41,42,43) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
2.	(PACKAGE-02) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in 2nd Main, 9th Cross and sub Cross Roads of Kuppusswamy Layout, Sub Cross Roads of Nagawara Village, 1st, 2nd and Cross Roads of Yellamma temple street, 4th, 5th, 6th, 7th, 8th and 9th Cross of Byrankunte 1st,2nd & 3rd Cross Govindapura Main Road, Behind Hanifia Masjid, 8th,11th,18th Cross Rashad Nagar & Byrappa Layout AMC Main Road, 1st, 2nd Cross Basava Nagar & 1st, 2nd Main Road Gandhi Nagar, 10th Cross Vinobha Nagar, & Sub Cross Road, 1st Main Cross, BM Layout, Hidayathnagar, Mukthinagara Sub Cross Roads at Ward No-22 Nagawara, 25-Govindapura, 26-Samadhananagara & Ward No-27 K.G.Halli (Anubanda-04, GO No:39,44,45 and 46) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
3.	(PACKAGE-03) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in Pillana Garden, Telegraph Street, PNT Colony, in Ramachandra Layout, KSFC Layout, Grance Garden, Thipanna Layout, Subash Layout, Lakshmiapathy Layout, and Kammanahalli Main Road, 2nd Block HBR Layout, 3rd Block HRBR Layout PNS Layout, AK Colony, Ashwathappa Layout, 2nd A,B,C,D,E Cross Roads HRBR 2nd Block in Ward No. 30-Kacharkanahalli, 31 -Kalyana Nagara & 28 Venkateshpura, 29-Lingarajapura (Anubanda-04, GO No:47,48,49,50) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
4.	(PACKAGE-04) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in Annaareddy Layout, Gopal Reddy Layout, Krishna Reddy Layout, HRBR 1st Block, OMBR Layout 8th cross road near oil mill road, Indira Street, Kammanahalli Village, Narayanappa Road to Muniswamappa Road, Narayanappa Road and Cross Roads Near Anganawadi, Muniswamappa Road, Near RS Palya Village Park & Krishnappa Layout, A, B Block Janikram Layout, Gundappa Mutt Road, Krishnappa Layout, Munithayappa Layout, Kanakadasa Layout Near Star World Bakery to Shadashiva Temple Road, Near KHB Quarters in Ward 32-Banasawadi, 33 HRBR Layout, 34 - Subbaiahnanapalya & Ward No- 35 Kammanahalli (Anubanda-04, GO No:51,52,53 & 54) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
5.	(PACKAGE-05) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in 7th to 16th Cross Roads Jaibharath Nagar, Mariamma Temple Road, Vivekananda Nagar Cross Roads, D'costa Layout, Balaji Layout, Lingarapura Village AK Colony, KR Garden, Nanjundappa Garden, Heerachand Layout, Nagainapalya Cross Roads, Satyanagar Cross Roads Secondary drain at Railway Parallel Road and KSFC Layout in Ward No.29 Lingarajapura, 36 Maruthi Seva Nagara, 37 Jeevanahalli & Ward No.22 Nagawara (Anubanda-04, GO No:55,56,57 & 58) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
6.	(PACKAGE-06) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in 5th, 8th, 9th, 10th Cross, Mehaboob Nagar and VHBCS Layout, Chikka Gulappa Cross Road, Noorani Masjid, Grape Garden, Nanjuppa Layout Cross Roads, 5th Block, 20th,21st,22nd Cross Roads Karnataka Bank 4th Block, CMR Garden, 8th ,9th Cross 5th,6th Main 3rd Block HBR Layout, 1st Cross Zafrulla Layout, 1st,2nd,3rd & 4th Cross New Nobel School, 9th,10th,11th Cross Roads 4th Cross Road Noor Masjid Roads in Ward No.22 Nagawara , 23 Hennur,24 -HBR Layout, 25 Govindapura (Anubanda-04, GO No:59,60,61,62) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 12,50,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
7.	(PACKAGE-07) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in Chuna Lane & Shampura Main Road , Makka Masjid Main Road & Cross Roads, Railway Parallel Roads, Back Side of EWS Quarters, Back Side of Primary Health Care Center Mariamma Temple Surrounding Area, Cross Roads of Arokyamma Layout, PNT Colony& Pillanna garden Main Road, Sait Palya, Kariyana Palya, 1st to 7th Cross Siddhartha School Roads a in Ward No.29 Lingarajapura, 26 Samadhanangara, 27 KG Halli, 28 Venkateshapura. (Anubanda-04, GO No:63,64,65,66) Estimated Cost: ₹.900.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.13,50,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 12,50,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
8.	(PACKAGE-08) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in Ramaiah Layout, Valmiki road 10th Cross Yellamma Road, Aralimara Road, 7th A Main HRBR Layout 2nd Block, Chairman Layout, 1st A, 1st B Cross HRBR Layout 1st Block Lakshamma Layout, Chandramma Layout, Green Park Layout, 8th A,B,C,D Cross Roads, 1st Block HRBR Layout, Bhuvanagiri, Seethamma Road, Kallama Road, Chinnappa Road, Netaji Road, Vinayaka Road, Sampanna Road in Ward No.33- HRBR Layout, 30-Kacharkanahalli, 31- Kalyana Nagara, 32-Banasawadi. (Anubanda-04, GO No:67,68,69 & 70) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.
9.	(PACKAG-09) Comprehensive Development of roads, drains and Footpath in Aralimara Road, Subbaiahnanapalya Village, Panchmukhi Temple Patel Nanjundappa Road, Munnegowda Road, Delhi Narayanappa Road, 6th Cross Jai Bharath Nagar, Cooke Town, Ashoka Road, North Road, Saddamappa Garden, Muniverappa Lane, Ananthram Layout Krishnappa Lane Road Near Jeevanahalli Sports Complex, Muniga Layout, Jeevanahalli Cross Roads and Surrounding Area in Ward No.37 Jeevanahalli 34, Subbaiahnanapalya , 35 Kammanahalli, 36 Maruthi Seva Nagar (Anubanda-04, GO No:71,72,73 & 74) Estimated Cost: ₹.1000.00 Lakhs, EMD : ₹.15,00,000.00, (1.00 lakh through e- payment balance ₹ 14,00,000.00 through BG/FDR should be submitted before opening of Technical bid.

Calendar of Events: (1) Tenders must be submitted online through KPP portal on or before 08-07-2026, 4:00 pm. (2) Pre Bid Meeting will be held on 01-07-2026 at 3:00 pm (3) Last Date and Time for Receipt of Tenders is 08-07-2026, 4:00 pm. (4) Date and Time for opening of Technical Bid is 09-07-2026, 4:30 pm. (5) Date & Time for Opening of Financial Bid (Will be intimated after obtaining approval for Technical Evaluation)

Sd/- Executive Engineer,
Sarvajnanagara Division, Zone-1, BNCC

SOUTHERN RAILWAY							
CHENNAI DIVISION							
E-Auction / E-tender Notice / Catering / 2026							
For and on behalf of the President of India, The Divisional Railway Manager, Chennai Division, Southern Railway, calls for bids (commercial) through E-Auction and E-tender for award of Catering stall contracts in the following Railway Stations / locations. The E-auction / E-tender scheduled are as detailed below:							
Sl. No.	Catalogue No / Tender No	Category	Location / Site	Auction / Tender Date	Mode of Tendering	Auction / Tender Timing	
1	MAS-PBCO-26-10	Premium Brand Catering Outlet	Puratchi Thalaivar Dr.M.G.R. Chennai Central	02.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
2	MAS-SMU-26-03	Catering stall	Gummidiipundi	03.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
3	Catering-26-01	Catering stall	Kanchipuram	06.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
4	Catering-26-01	Catering stall	St.Thomas Mount	06.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
5	MAS-SMU-26-04	Catering stall	Chennai Egmore	08.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
6	MAS-SMU-26-04	Catering stall	Puratchi Thalaivar Dr.M.G.R. Chennai Central	08.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
7	MAS-MPS-26-05	Catering stall	Mambalam	08.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
8	MAS-MPS-26-05	Catering stall	Villivakkam	08.07.26	E-Auction	15:00	
9	COMML-26011-GMU-78-PON	Catering stall	Ponneri	09.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
10	COMML-26012-GMU-68-CGL	Catering stall	Chengalpattu	09.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
11	COMML-26013-GMU-12-VLK	Catering stall	Villivakkam	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
12	COMML-26014-GMU-44-MS	Catering stall	Chennai Egmore	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
13	COMML-26015-GMU-45-MS	Catering stall	Chennai Egmore	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
14	COMML-26016-GMU-50-MKK	Catering stall	Kodambakkam	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
15	COMML-26017-GMU-57-STM	Catering stall	St.Thomas Mount	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
16	COMML-26018-GMU-63-TBM	Catering stall	Tambaram	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
17	COMML-26019-GMU-66-MLMR	Catering stall	Melmaruvathur	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
18	COMML-26020-GMU-65-TBMS	Catering stall	Tambaram Sanatorium	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
19	COMML-26021-GMU-67-CGL	Catering stall	Chengalpattu	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
20	COMML-26022-GMU-72-MASS	Catering stall	Chennai Central Suburban	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
21	COMML-26023-GMU-74-MASS	Catering stall	Chennai Central Suburban	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
22	COMML-26024-FJFS-08-MBM	Juice stall	Mambalam	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
23	COMML-26025-FJFS-11-TBM	Juice stall	Tambaram	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
24	COMML-26026-GMU-69-CGL	Catering stall	Chengalpattu	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
25	COMML-26027-MMPS-07-PER	Milk stall	Perambur	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
26	COMML-26028-MMPS-14-TBM	Milk stall	Tambaram	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
27	COMML-26029-MMPS-26-PV	Milk stall	Pallavaram	15.07.26	E-tender	15:00	
28	20625-SLR-F1-MAS-BGKT-26-3	SLR	MAS-BGKT	29.06.26	E-Auction	15:00	
29	12842-SLR-R1-MAS-HWH-26-1	SLR	MAS-HWH	29.06.26	E-Auction	15:00	
30	12603-SLR-R1-MAS-CHZ-26-1	SLR	MAS-CHZ	29.06.26	E-Auction	15:00	
31	22842-SLR-F1-TBM-SRC-26-3	SLR	TBM-SRC	29.06.26	E-Auction	15:00	
32	12375-SLR-F1-TBM-JSME-26-1	SLR	TBM-JSME	29.06.26	E-Auction	15:00	
33	16101-SLR-F1-TBM-QLN-26-3	SLR	TBM-QLN	29.06.26	E-Auction	15:00	
34	MAS-PARKING-392	PARKING	Chengalpattu (Lot 1 & 2)	30.06.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
35	MAS-PARKING-393	PARKING	Perambur South Side	03.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
36	MAS-PARKING-393	PARKING	Vandalur (Two Wheeler)	03.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
37	MAS-PARKING-394	PARKING	Chelpet (East side)	06.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
38	MAS-PARKING-394	PARKING	Guindy	06.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
39	MAS-PARKING-395	PARKING	SKL CAR	08.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
40	MAS-PARKING-396	PARKING	Perambur (North Side)	09.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
41	MAS-PARKING-396	PARKING	Villivakkam (South Side)	09.07.2026	E-Auction	15:00	
42	NFR-MAS-VLCYEMU	Advertising - Train Interior and Exterior	Velachery-EMU	02.07.2026	E-Auction	15:30	
43	NFR-MAS-PEROSD	Advertising On Station Premise (Digital)	Perambur	03.07.2026	E-Auction	15:30	
44	NFR-MAS-BSS-PEW	Battery swapping stations	Perambur Loco Works	08.07.2026	E-Auction	15:30	
45	NFR-MAS-OOH-GDY	Out-of-Home advertisements	Guindy	08.07.2026	E-Auction	15:30	
46	NFR-MAS-Unipole	Out-of-Home advertisements through unipoles	Salt Coasters, Perambur Loco Works, Perambur, Vyasapadi Jeeva, Basin Bridge	09.07.2026	E-Auction	15:30	
47	NFR-MAS-Bus bay	Out-of-Home advertisements	Chennai Central	10.07.2026	E-Auction	15:30	

All other details can be viewed on the website - www.ireps.gov.in.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH



OBITUARY

Mrs.VASANTHA SUBRAMANYAN (87), Mother of Ms. Shanti Puducheri, Chennai - 600031, expired on 26-06-2026. Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai-17 (Ph: 28340500).

D.SATHYABHAMA

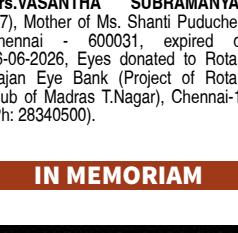
(w/o Late Sri P.S.Ramachandran)

Passed away peacefully on June 24, 2026

Deeply Mourned by: P.R.Subramanian & Janaki P.R.Devavaraj & Nagalakshmi Adithya & Niamh Aishwarya, Soundarya & Shreeya

9841010900 / 9845031283

DEATH



IN MEMORIAM

"What we commonly call Death does not destroy us it only causes a separation of spirit and its body."

IN MEMORIAM

20.12.1963 27.06.2002

Dear AKHIL, we think of you every moment and miss your presence in our lives.

Bansal family & friends

REMEMBRANCE



Fondly Remembered

15.11.1951 - 27.06.2011

Sri. K.V. RAMANI (Anna)

Deeply Missed by: Vijay K. Ramani, Sumathi Natarajan, Janani Vijay, Nataraj & Friends

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



SECOND YEAR ANNIVERSARY

G.BALASUBRAMANYAN

(Chartered Accountant)

DOB: 26.07.1939 DOD: 27.06.2024

Founder Partner

M/s G BALU ASSOCIATES LLP

Chartered Accountants

Fondly Remembered By

Partners & Employees

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. and Printed by Ra Babu Vijay at THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Plot 8-6 & 8-7, CMDA Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, Chengalpattu Taluk, Chengalpattu Dist., Pin 603209. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).

ISSN 0971 - 751X



M CH-CHE

Activists flag safety, accommodation lapses after Tiruvallur seafood unit ammonia leak

Labour rights activists and experts point to gaps in workplace safety and provision of safe accommodation for workers. They say specific operations such as ammonia-based refrigeration or handling of certain chemicals should attract additional safety and environmental compliance requirements

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

After an ammonia gas leak at a private seafood processing and export unit near Periyapalayam in Tiruvallur district killed 15 migrant workers, labour rights activists and experts have pointed to gaps in workplace safety and in the provision of safe rest areas and accommodation for workers.

The workers, many of them women from Odisha and Assam, aged between 19 and 25, were off duty and resting in the dormitory when the leak occurred.

R. Geetha of the Unorganised Workers Federation said living spaces are as important as worksites, especially for migrant workers, as employers are responsible for the accommodation given to them.

She said that while the Factories Act, 1948 requires shelters and rest rooms to be adequate, ventilated, cool and clean, and prohibits eating in work



One of the affected workers being examined at Vels Medical College and Hospital in Tiruvallur district recently. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

rooms where a lunch room exists, these norms are often not followed. Workers are made to stay in cramped and overcrowded spaces, she said.

She added that for many migrant workers, there is hardly any separation between the workplace and their place of stay, which often blurs the line between work and rest. This leaves them vulnerable to being overworked, affects their mental well-being, and also puts them at risk even if they are off duty when an accident or industrial mishap occurs.

A.R. Shanthi of the All India Trade Union Congress and the Working Women's Forum said a shrimp processing unit would generally not fall under the Factories Act's category of a 'hazardous process' factory, as seafood processing is not among the industries listed in the First Schedule.

However, she added, specific operations within such units – such as ammonia-based refrigeration or handling of certain chemicals – should still attract additional safety and environmental compliance requirements.

Dr. Shanthi said every factory must have its own evacuation plan, fire prevention protocol, and safety measures in place, but questioned whether these were actually implemented or regularly checked.

In industries such as seafood processing, where large quantities of ammonia are used for cold storage, the potential risk is significant, she said.

Fr. Simolin of Don Bosco Migrant Services said companies, irrespective of size, do not take worker safety or compliance with safety mechanisms seriously.

Referring to the incident where a migrant worker died after a ramp at a makeshift accommodation of a private company collapsed earlier this month, and the 2025 Ennore SEZ thermal plant project accident in which nine workers died, he said companies failed to put adequate safeguards in place.

He said that while compensation may be paid af-

ter such incidents, survivors are effectively pushed out of work, and no meaningful changes follow.

Call for judicial inquiry
Penn Thozhilalar Sangam has urged the State government to constitute a high-powered judicial inquiry into the ammonia leak at St. Peter and Paul Seafood factory, alleging serious lapses in workplace safety and labour protection.

In a memorandum addressed to Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, the Labour Department, and the Directorate of Industrial Safety and Health, the federation said the incident was not merely an industrial accident but one that raised questions about workplace safety, labour rights, regulatory oversight, and the treatment of migrant and Adivasi women workers.

It demanded that criminal cases be registered against the owners, managers, and others responsible under provisions relating to culpable homicide, negligence, and violations of

labour and safety laws.

It sought the publication of a detailed report on the incident, permission for an independent civil society fact-finding team to visit the site, and unrestricted access for trade unions, lawyers, and labour rights groups to meet the workers.

Expressing concern that workers housed at a marriage hall after the incident could be sent back to their native places without informed consent, the groups urged the government to ensure humanitarian assistance and facilitate conciliation proceedings between the workers and the management.

Calling the tragedy symptomatic of wider labour exploitation, the organisations urged the government to inspect seafood processing units and other hazardous industries across the State, publish the findings, and strengthen coordination among departments.

AGENT HELD
» PAGE 6



Kabaddi coach booked under POCSO Act

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 29-year-old Kabaddi coach has been booked by the All Women Police, Kan-nagi Nagar, under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, after he allegedly sexually assaulted a minor trainee.

The police said the accused, who has operated a local Kabaddi club for several years, allegedly assaulted the 17-year-old girl at her residence last week. The incident came to

light after the girl's teammates noticed a significant change in her behaviour and found her in physical distress.

FIR registered

Following a formal complaint lodged at the All Women Police Station, an FIR was registered under Sections 7 (sexual assault), 8 (punishment for sexual assault), and 9 (aggravated sexual assault) of the POCSO Act.

The police have launched a search for the suspect.

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	26
Chennai Airport	37	29
Chennai City	37	28

Chennai Airport Today
36°C The weather will be very warm and uneasy. Night will also be uneasy. Spell of light rain and thundershowers may occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Chances of light rain and thundershowers. Night will also be uneasy.

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THE HINDU
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Stalin says he has not taken a decision on contesting in bypoll

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Friday said that no decision had yet been taken on contesting in an Assembly bypoll.

Recently, DMK strongman K.N. Nehru said Mr. Stalin would soon re-enter the Assembly. This had triggered speculation on the likelihood of the DMK president contesting from the Tiruchi East seat, vacated

DMK strongman K.N. Nehru recently said Mr. Stalin would soon re-enter the Assembly

by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who had retained the Perambur constituency.

Responding to journalists in Chennai, Mr. Stalin said, "No decision has been taken, yet. I shall let you know after a decision is taken."

Webinar on zoonotic diseases to be held today

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu will conduct a free health webinar on the topic 'Ebola: Preparing for the Next Pandemic' from 3 p.m. to 4 p.m. on Saturday.

The session will explore how zoonotic diseases – infectious diseases that spread from animals to humans – have become an increasing global public health concern. Using Ebola as a key case study, experts will explain how such diseases emerge, the factors that contribute to their spread, and why outbreaks are becoming more frequent in an increasingly interconnected world.



quent in an increasingly interconnected world.

Expert panellists include Parthasarathy Rajendran, executive director, Doctors Without Borders/Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF) South Asia, who will

discuss how zoonotic diseases emerge and spread, lessons from humanitarian health emergencies, the factors driving spillover events, and the importance of the One Health approach and global collaboration in

responding to emerging infectious diseases.

Hamsadvari Kuganatham, consultant, WHO South-East Asia Regional Office, and Global Health research manager, The Global Health Network, University of Oxford, will speak about strengthening disease surveillance and early warning systems, the role of International Health Regulations in outbreak preparedness, building research capacity, and improving data sharing during health emergencies.

Vijayalakshmi Balakrishnan, senior consultant, Infectious Diseases, Kauvery

Hospitals, Chennai, will discuss managing zoonotic diseases in clinical practice, common zoonotic infections, infection prevention and control measures in healthcare settings, antimicrobial resistance, and the importance of public awareness, vaccination, and preventive strategies.

The session will be moderated by Zubeda Hamid, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Hindu*.

To register for the webinar, click on newsth.live/healthwebinar-reg or scan the QR code.



E-OPEN TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender notice no.: CRW-HRT-MRSP-REFURB-1, Date: 24.06.2026
For and on behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut invites open e-tender for the following works as detailed:-
1. Name of work with its location: Refurbishment of Coaches at Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut for One years.
2. Approx. cost of the work: Rs. 21017938.00 (Rupees Two Crore Ten Lakhs Seventeen Thousand Nine Hundred Thirty-Eight and Seventy Paise Only).
3. Cost of Tender Form: Nil.
4. Earnest Money to be deposited: Rs. 420400.00 (Rupees Four Lakh Twenty Thousand Four Hundred only).
5. Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of Tender: The tender have to be submitted online on <https://www.ireps.gov.in> website up to 11:30 hrs. on 15.07.2026 and will be opened on the same day at 11:45 hrs.
6. Website particulars, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc: Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: <https://www.ireps.gov.in> & full details of notice can be seen on notice board in the office of Chief Workshop Manager, Administrative Building, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut, Nalanda, Bihar-803110. All corrigendum if any will be uploaded on website if required.
Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer
Carriage Repair Workshop/Harnaut
PR/0456/CRW-HRT/MECH/T/26-27/48

भारतीय सूचना प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान कोट्टयम
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY KOTTAYAM
(An Institute of National Importance under the Ministry of Education, Govt. of India)
Valluvor P.O., Palai, Kottayam (DK), Kerala - 686 655
Tel: 0482-202100 (Office), 202138 (Academic), 202110 (Security), 202103 (Accounts)
Emails: rector@iiitkottayam.ac.in & web@iiitkottayam.ac.in
No. IIITK/01/05/2026/2529 Date: June 25, 2026
RECRUITMENT - CONTRACT FACULTY POSITIONS
Indian Institute of Information Technology Kottayam (IIIT Kottayam) invites online applications from Indian Nationals for empanelment as **Contract Faculty in Computer Science & Engineering and its interdisciplinary areas**.
Interested candidates may apply online through <https://adhocrecruit.iiitkottayam.ac.in>
Last date of application: 5:00 pm (IST) on 08.07.2026.
Interview schedule: 10.07.2026 – 10.00 a.m (IST) onwards
For details, visit iiitkottayam.ac.in.
Sd/-
REGISTRAR

UT ADMINISTRATION OF DADRA & NAGAR HAVELI AND DAMAN & DIU
DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH & FAMILY WELFARE, SILVASSA
No. DMHS/Specialists/Khanvel-SDH/2025/203/1741
Date: 26/06/2026
ADVERTISEMENT
Department of Health & Family Welfare, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu invites application from eligible candidates for the posts of Specialists to be filled on a short-term contract basis.
Last date of receiving the application is **09/07/2026**
O/o Department of Health & Family Welfare, Silvassa, DNH
NO: IP/DMN/2/5/2026-27/278 dated 26/6/2026

17th Graduation Day
Class of 2024
Saturday, 27 June 2026
10.00 a.m. - 6.00 p.m.
Kamarajar Arangam, Anna Salai, Teynampet, Chennai
Graduation Address & Degree Conferal
Dr. S. Armstrong
Member, VC Convener Committee
Professor & Head, Department of English, Professor & Head i/c, Centre for Endangered Languages, University of Madras
Dr. Rita John
Registrar,
University of Madras
Dr. C. Arulvasu
Controller of Examinations i/c
University of Madras
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Top 10 University Rank Holders - 49
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Secretary
Dr. Harish L. Mehta
Associate Secretary
Dr. S. Padmavathi
Principal

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE FOR SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS
E-TENDER NOTICE No.: NIT/14/26/25, Dated 23.06.2026.

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Description	Tender Closing/Opening Date	Qty.
1.	04261356	BRUSHLESS ALTERNATOR OF 4.5 KW CAP	09.07.2026	53 Nos.
2.	03262059	ELASTOMER UNIT(RUBBER PAD RF-8) for RF-361 DRAFT GEAR	09.07.2026	6860 Nos.
3.	02264106	Metalized Carbon Strip suitable for High reach Pantographs	15.07.2026	412 Nos.
4.	03261037A	Air brake hose pipe coupling	20.07.2026	12939 Nos.
5.	03263180	Set of Kit for pins, split pins and washer consisting of 9 items for Bogie mounted brake	22.07.2026	7569 Sets
6.	03262970	Repair kit for Automatic Pressure Modification (APM-EL-60) consisting of 15 items.	23.07.2026	7185 Sets
7.	06260113	ELASTIC RAIL CLIP(EJC) J CLIP WITH HIGHER TOE LOAD FOR FISH PLATED	14.07.2026	3,62,542 Nos
8.	06260078	HYV-66 INSULATING LINER FOR USE WITH WIDER PSC SLEEPER TO DRAWING NO. RDSO/T-8746	14.07.2026	15,88,230 Nos.
9.	06265031B	Supply installation and commissioning of GOLIATH CRANE-5T at Wheel Park	14.07.2026	01 Nos.

Tender Closing/Opening Time: At 10.30 hours
Railways reserves the right to issue any Corrigendum to the tenders. Corrigendum & Important Notice to vendors may be seen in the link www.ireps.gov.in
CPR/10/PHI/238 For Principal Chief Materials Manager/Bilaspur.
f South East Central Railway x @secrail

THE KARUR TEXTILE MANUFACTURER EXPORTERS ASSOCIATION
Golden Jubilee Year
1975 - 2025
50 YEARS OF DEVELOPMENT AND LEGACY
Honouring Our Past • Celebrating Our Present • Building Our Future
Five decades of dedication, unity and progress in strengthening the Karur Textile Industry. A journey of trust, innovation, sustainability and global excellence.
RECOGNISING OUR VETERANS
Honouring the visionaries and pioneers who laid the foundation of our remarkable journey.
HONOURING COMMUNITY & INDUSTRY LEADERS
Celebrating the outstanding contributions of leaders who continue to inspire and uplift our industry.
SETTING OUR VISION
Unveiling the vision for a stronger, sustainable and globally competitive Karur Textile Cluster.
ROAD MAP TO THE FUTURE
Charting our collective road map to achieve greater growth, innovation and global leadership.
GOLDEN JUBILEE CELEBRATIONS
SATURDAY 27th JUNE 2026 4:30 PM ONWARDS ATLAS KALAIRANGAM KARUR
CHIEF GUEST
Shri GIRIRAJ SINGH
Hon'ble Union Minister for Textiles, Government of India
DISTINGUISHED GUESTS
State Ministers, Government Officials, Industry Leaders and Esteemed Invitees will grace the occasion.
All are Warmly Welcome!
TOGETHER WE HONOUR OUR LEGACY. TOGETHER WE BUILD OUR FUTURE.

INBRIEF



Identity cards for students of Classes 10, 12 soon: Minister

Minister for Revenue and Disaster Management K.A. Sengottaiyan on Friday said the State government would issue identity cards soon to students of Classes 10 and 12, with details such as their address, community, blood group, Aadhaar number, and phone number. Addressing the media in Gobichettipalayam, Mr. Sengottaiyan said students were required to produce community certificates every year for various purposes. To simplify the process, the government had decided to introduce the identity cards, which would integrate all their details, he added. Mr. Sengottaiyan said Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had directed officials to complete the exercise at the earliest.



Palaniswami announces more appointments to party posts

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Friday announced the appointment of a few more colleagues to party posts. In a statement, he said Arcot legislator S.M. Sukumar, Sattur's former MLA S.G. Subramanian, and Erode's former Deputy Mayor K.C. Palanisamy had been made deputy propaganda secretaries of the party, and former Minister V.M. Rajalakshmi the joint secretary of the women's wing. Mr. Palaniswami would chair a meeting of the women's wing at the party's headquarters on July 1.

Film producer made Special Representative of T.N. in Delhi

The State government has appointed Venkata Narayana K., the producer of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's unreleased last film, *Jananayagan*, as the Special Representative to the Government of Tamil Nadu in New Delhi. A Government Order dated June 23, 2026, issued by the Chief Secretary, said the temporary post was being created for a period of one year with effect from the date on which the appointee takes charge, or till the need for it ceases. The G.O. said the terms and conditions of the appointment would be issued separately. AMMK general secretary T.T.V. Dhinakaran criticised the move. In a social media post, he said the people had voted for the TVK and Mr. Vijay for providing good governance, and not for indulging in 'favouritism'. He demanded that the appointment be cancelled. The AIADMK's IT wing wondered whether the TVK regime was functioning as a 'proxy' of the Congress government in Karnataka, contending that the appointee belonged to Karnataka, and was based out of Bengaluru.

A convert to Islam cannot claim the status of Backward Class Muslim, rules High Court

Madurai Bench declares a 2024 G.O. allowing converts to claim BC status unconstitutional. It cites HC's 1951 verdict, which held that when a Hindu converts to Islam, he becomes a Muslim, and his place in Muslim society is not determined by the caste to which he belonged before conversion

B. Tilak Chandar
MADURAI

A convert to Islam cannot claim the status of a Backward Class Muslim; he is only a Muslim, and that's all there is to it, the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has ruled, while declaring a 2024 G.O. allowing converts to claim such status unconstitutional.

The court was hearing a petition filed in 2022 by a man from Thoothukudi district, who had embraced Islam and changed his name. He was born to Hindu parents. The certificate issued by the Sunnath Jamath, Kayathar, in 2015 stated that the petitioner had embraced Islam. He had applied for a community certificate certifying him as 'Muslim Lebbai', a faith he claimed to follow. However, the Kayathar Tahsildar rejected his application. Challenging it, he moved the court.



Meanwhile, a G.O. issued in 2024 ordered that a convert to Islam from the Backward Classes, Most Backward Classes, Denotified Communities or Scheduled Castes may be treated as BC (Muslim) for getting the benefit of reservation, and on such conversion, (s)he may be issued with a community certificate as belonging to one of the notified seven sects.

However, the State said a convert from a forward community to Islam would not get the BC (Muslim) tag. Only those who already enjoyed the benefit of reservation in their origi-

Categorising certain sects as Backward and the remaining as Forward is antithetical to Quranic injunctions. Islam seeks to establish an egalitarian society

MADURAI BENCH

nal religion would not lose it on account of conversion to Islam. Social balance will not be affected, it was submitted.

A Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and P.B. Balaji said that as early as in 1951, the Madras High Court had held that when a Hindu gets converted to Islam, he becomes just a Mussalman, and his place in Muslim society is not determined by the caste to which he belonged before his conversion. It was further held that when a member of one of the castes or sub-castes converts to Islam, he ceases to be a member of any caste.

Minister claims video showed him crushing child's tablet, not drugs

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Minister for Human Resources Management D. Sarathkumar on Friday denied allegations circulating on social media that a viral video from an Indian Premier League (IPL) match showed him allegedly preparing to snort drugs. The video showed him using a credit or debit card to make a powder line with a white substance placed on a mobile phone screen.

Addressing the media, he said the video was recorded about two years ago, and had resurfaced now with "rumours".

'False impression'

He said the clip showed him crushing a tablet for his one-and-a-half-year-old child, after his wife had told him that the child was refusing to take the tablet and was spitting it out. The Minister said they crushed the tablet and mixed the powder with a liquid to make it easier for



D. Sarathkumar

The Minister says the video was recorded about two years ago, and has resurfaced now with 'rumours'

the child to consume it.

The Minister alleged that the video had been selectively shared on social media to create a false impression that he was handling drugs.

"The video has been wrongly interpreted. Those who were present with me know what had actually happened," he said.

CM flags off and takes part in run to raise awareness against drug abuse

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

On the occasion of the International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking on Friday, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay flagged off and took part in the 'Anti Drug Run 2026', organised by the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu in Chennai.

An official press release said the objective of the run was to channel the energy of young people into constructive pursuits, promote a healthy lifestyle, and bring about positive change in society.

Around 15,000 people took part in the 6-km run from Arignar Anna Memorial on Kamarajar Salai to Island Grounds.

Renowned sportspersons including Mohan Kumar (Athletics), V. Baskaran (Hockey), Thirumal Valavan (Hockey), Mohammed Riyas (Hockey), Raman (Table Tennis), Sharath Kamal (Table Tennis), Srinivasa Rao (Table Tennis), Dronacharya Award recipient, Joshna Chinappa (Squash), Arjuna



Star campaigner: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay participating in the run in Chennai on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Award recipient), and Anitha Pauldurai (Basketball); Padma Shri awardee) took part in the run.

Earlier, the Chief Minister signed on the pledge board displaying the message: 'Sports-ah edu, drugs-ah vidu' (Take up sports, give up drugs).

Ministers N. Anand, Aadhav Arjuna, P. Venkataramanan, N. Marie Wilson, and R. Kumar; Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar; Director-General of Police Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal, and senior officials were present on the occasion.

Police medals

The Chief Minister's Police Medals have been an-

Marakkayar or Deccani Muslim by birth alone. It is ridiculous to suggest that one can be converted into a Rowther Muslim," the court said.

'Just a Mussalman'

The order said that, as held by the Division Bench of the Madras High Court more than 75 years ago, one becomes a Muslim upon conversion to Islam. The Division Bench used the expression, 'just a Mussalman'. He cannot be pigeonholed into any particular sect or community which can be only by virtue of one's birth therein. When the proposition laid down by the Division Bench is holding the field, it cannot be undone by issuing a mere government order, the court said.

"The doctrine of separation of powers is an entrenched principle in the Constitution, and it is an essential constituent of rule of law. This principle applies to the final judg-

ments of the courts. The legislature cannot declare any decision of a court of law to be void or of no effect," the court said.

Against this backdrop, it is not open to the State government to issue a G.O. undermining the decision.

"That is exactly what the government has done by recognising that there can be conversion to any one of the seven sects of Muslims identified as Backward Class Muslim. The sheer arbitrariness of the impugned G.O. becomes manifest for one more reason. The Backward Classes Commission's recommendation as well as the G.O. provide for accommodating BC/MBC/DNC/SC convertees in any one of the seven slots. A SC who is at the bottom-most rung of the social ladder is put on par with a BC. The Supreme Court, in a catena of decisions, has held that OBCs and SCs form separate categories," the court said.

Magistrates should not cite hypertechnicalities to deny birth affidavits for surrogate babies, says HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Judicial magistrates should not harp on hypertechnicalities and consequently refuse to pass orders concerning the parentage and custody of a baby to be born through surrogacy, just because the woman intending to be the biological mother happens to be between 50 and 51 years of age, the Madras High Court has held.

Justice Shamim Ahmed said the legal requirement that the woman intending to be the biological mother must be between 23 and 50 years of age could not be construed to mean that a woman aged 50 years, nine months and two days on the date of application would become ineligible for surrogacy.

The judge said the wo-



A woman intending to be the biological mother will not become ineligible for surrogacy just because she is between 50 and 51 years of age, says HC

man intending to be the biological mother would become ineligible only after attaining 51 years of age and therefore, in the present case, the Joint Director of Health Services, in the officer's capacity as the appropriate authority under the Surrogacy (Regulation) Act of 2021, had rightly issued an eligibility

certificate to the intending couple.

'Exceeded jurisdiction'

The court agreed with senior counsel Hasan Mohamed Jinnah, who had been appointed as an *amicus curiae*, that a judicial magistrate in Namakkal had exceeded the judicial officer's jurisdiction by assessing the validity of the eligibility certificate, and giving a finding that the certificate was invalid simply because of the age of the applicant.

"Unless the eligibility certificates issued by the appropriate authority under the 2021 Surrogacy (Regulation) Act are set aside by a competent forum, or shown to be *ex-facie* illegal, fraudulent, or without jurisdiction, the Judicial Magistrate ought not to reassess the merits of such certificates," Jus-

tice Ahmed said.

After recording the arguments advanced by Government Counsel (criminal side) R. John Sathyan and the intending couple's counsel Niranjan Rajagopalan, the judge ruled that in the present case, the Judicial Magistrate had also erred in insisting on the examination of the surrogate mother's husband.

He pointed out that the Surrogacy Act states that no surrogacy or surrogacy procedures should be conducted, undertaken, performed or initiated, unless the intending couple/woman submits a host of documents, which include a judicial order concerning the parentage and custody of a baby to be born through surrogacy.

The judicial order, intended to serve as the birth affidavit after the surrogate baby is born, had to

be obtained under Section 4(iii)(a)(II) of the Act, and the provision clearly states that the application for such an order could be made by the intending couple or the intending single woman and the surrogate mother.

"The Section does not require the husband of the surrogate mother to be a party to the proceeding or depose evidence with regard to the issue," the judge said.

'Extend validity'

Further, taking note that the eligibility certificate, valid for a period of one year, had expired in the present case on May 23, 2026, because of the long legal proceedings that the intending couple had to face before the magistrate, the judge ordered that its validity should be extended for another year.

Ammonia leak: agent who brought migrant workers from Odisha held

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tiruvallur district police on Friday arrested the agent who brought migrant workers from Odisha to the private seafood processing unit near Periyapalayam, where an ammonia gas leak has claimed 15 lives so far.

The arrested man was identified as Suresh Prabhath, 41, of Odisha. Police sources said he was arrested under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The sources said Suresh was identified at the initial stage of the probe a couple of days ago. But he was kept under surveillance at a private marriage hall, along with migrant workers, until the bodies of the victims were identified.

The police have already arrested factory owners M.

Joseph Jegan, 49, of Royapuram, and M. Mohan, 59, of Tondiarpet, and factory manager R. Daniel, 70.

Toll rises to 15

Two more women workers died, taking the toll to 15 on Friday, according to a bulletin issued by the Health Department. The deceased were identified as Priti Devi of Jharkhand and Budhubari Naik of Odisha. While the bulletin has not disclosed the age of the deceased, it reflected a change in the identity of one of the victims. The name of the 13th victim, earlier listed as Pinki Juanga of Odisha, was changed to Deepanjali Juanga of Kendujar district, Odisha.

A total of 40 persons are undergoing treatment at various hospitals. Two of them are on ventilator support and nine are receiving nasal oxygen. The condi-

tion of 29 persons is stable. So far, 28 persons have been discharged after treatment.

The mortal remains of 11 persons were airlifted to Odisha and two to Assam, while the remains of two others will be transported once legal formalities are completed.

CPI(M) Politburo member K. Balakrishnan has demanded ₹25 lakh in compensation for the families of each of the workers who died in the ammonia leak, alleging that the tragedy was the result of gross negligence on the part of the factory management.

The North Chennai district unit of the Communist Party of India (CPI) urged the government to release the report of the inquiry committee immediately, and provide ₹25 lakh each in compensation to the families of the deceased.

Six suspected Bangladeshis held with fake documents in Kochi: police

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala Police have arrested six suspected Bangladeshi nationals who were allegedly staying illegally at Eroor in Kochi.

The men were arrested from a scrap dealer's shop at Karukappadom Road near Eroor on Thursday following a tip-off. They had been working at the shop for some time, the Hill Palace police said on Friday.

The arrested were identified as Rakiv Shaba, 24, Muhammad Sohail Faraz, 33, Tarek Abdul Monnan, 21, Sogir, 18, Maidhi Hazida, 32, and Muhammad Agin, 39. Police sources said the identity cards and other documents recovered from them were found to be fake. The accused have been charged with entering or remaining in India without the required travel documents under Section 21 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025 and forgery under Section 336(2) and 340 (2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The police said a detailed probe would be conducted into how the accused reached Kerala. They will be produced before a court, the police said. The arrests come close on the heels of the Kuruppampady police apprehending a suspected Bangladeshi national who was staying at Asamannur and working at a plywood factory there.

No decision on low-alcohol drinks yet: Kerala Minister

Decision on selling such beverages in Kerala will be based solely on the liquor policy, which is yet to be prepared; CM has clearly stated his stance on the issue, says Excise Minister M. Liju

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The decision on selling low-alcohol beverages in Kerala will be based solely on the liquor policy, which is yet to be prepared, Excise Minister M. Liju has said. Addressing a press conference in Thiruvananthapuram on Friday, he said that the Budget proposal for tax cuts on low-alcohol beverages was considering this future possibility, and not a decision to be implemented immediately.

“As per the information available to me, only after the UDF government comes out with a comprehensive liquor policy will a final decision on the sales of low-alcohol beverages be taken,” he said.

Chief Minister V.D. Sathesnan has clearly stated that the tax cuts are not for immediate sales, but that these will be the slabs when the sales happen in



Decision pending: M. Liju says V.D. Sathesnan has stated that the tax cuts are not for immediate sales. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

hensive liquor policy will a final decision on the sales of low-alcohol beverages be taken,” he said.

Chief Minister V.D. Sathesnan has clearly stated that the tax cuts are not for immediate sales, but that these will be the slabs when the sales happen in

the future after the liquor policy comes into force, Mr. Liju added.

He said that before the sales of low-alcohol beverages can take place, the brand registration application has to go through the Excise Commissioner.

“As the Excise Minister,

my stand right now is that such applications should be rejected. However, if the required changes are made in the liquor policy, then it can be allowed,” he said.

Mr. Liju said that the idea of low-alcohol beverages was first introduced by the previous Left Democratic Front (LDF) government through the liquor policy of 2022, following which the Abkari Rules were amended as per a government order in 2023.

To a question on whether he was unaware of the tax cut proposal in the Budget, he said that it is usually not a practice for Finance Ministers to discuss the tax proposals with the respective Ministers.

Karnataka BJP president denies ‘links’ with CM amid MLC polls row

The Hindu Bureau
DHARMASTHALA

Denying business or any other links with Congress leader and Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, the Karnataka unit president of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) B.Y. Vijayendra has said that his own party colleagues have spread “false information”.

“If I had links with Mr. Shivakumar, I would be as guilty as some of our MLAs, who cross-voted in the MLC elections and are working against the party,” he said on Friday.

‘Party men behind lies’

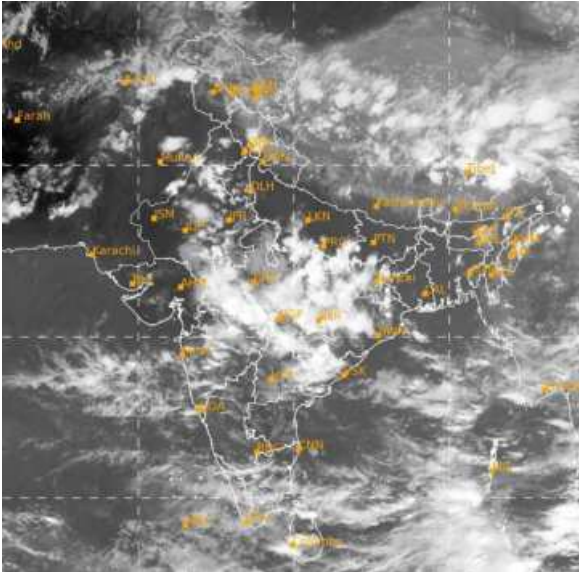
“I categorically deny business or any other links with D.K. Shivakumar. The respect that I have given to Mr. Shivakumar is the one given to a fellow head of the State unit of a party. I know some of my own party colleagues have spread this information (about his alleged links with Mr. Shivakumar),” he said.

Though voting in the Legislative Council elections was through a secret ballot, in the coming days, truth will reveal which BJP legislators had cross-voted, he said.

In the recent Council elections, the ruling Congress won five of the seven seats, while the BJP secured two and JD(S) drew a blank. Cross-voting by some BJP and JD(S) legislators helped Congress secure 11 votes more than expected, leaving the BJP red-faced.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: AQICN/CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.45 HRS)

Forecast for Saturday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Konkan & Goa, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal, Kerala and Mahe. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Uttar Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	0.8	33.7	26.1	Kurnool	3.1	34.6	26.7
Ahmedabad	0.8	40.7	29.3	Lucknow	—	42.4	30.4
Aizawl	0.1	29.2	23.0	Madurai	—	39.0	26.6
Bangaluru	30.7	21.3	—	Mangaluru	18.6	31.3	24.0
Bhopal	33.8	22.2	—	Mumbai	—	33.6	25.8
Bhubaneswar	2.5	40.3	27.8	Mysuru	—	30.4	20.2
Chandigarh	—	40.2	26.3	New Delhi	—	41.5	28.7
Chennai	2.4	38.0	27.6	Patna	—	39.0	28.8
Coimbatore	—	33.2	23.0	Port Blair	9.9	31.0	26.0
Dehradun	—	36.8	25.3	Prayagraj	—	42.0	29.5
Gangtok	14	25.6	18.6	Puducherry	4.2	38.3	27.4
Goa	19.6	33.0	23.8	Pune	—	34.3	22.9
Guwahati	—	34.4	27.4	Raipur	—	37.6	27.4
Hubballi	—	30.0	23.0	Ranchi	—	32.5	24.1
Hyderabad	—	31.2	25.4	Shillong	—	24.8	17.0
Imphal	—	32.1	22.3	Shimla	—	28.2	20.0
Jaipur	16.4	38.7	26.6	Srinagar	—	32.4	18.0
Kochi	10.8	30.4	26.0	Thiruvananthapuram	3	30.4	25.2
Kohima	—	26.0	20.0	Tiruchirappalli	—	36.7	27.4
Kolkata	21.8	35.1	25.4	Vijayawada	—	37.0	28.5
Kozhikode	12.3	32.4	25.6	Visakhapatnam	—	33.9	29.4

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE
Ahmedabad	—	—	—	—	—	—
Bangaluru	—	—	—	—	—	—
Chennai	—	—	—	—	—	—
Delhi	—	4	14	10	139	194
Hyderabad	—	—	—	—	—	—
Kolkata	—	—	—	—	—	—
Lucknow	—	—	—	—	—	—
Mumbai	—	—	—	—	—	—
Pune	—	—	—	—	—	—
Visakhapatnam	—	—	—	—	—	—

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Modinagar, Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 259 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram recorded a healthy AQI score of 18

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

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Tragic evening

Venezuela's quake holds lessons on the importance of preparedness

On Wednesday two earthquakes, of magnitudes 7.1 and 7.5, struck seconds apart, levelling large parts of Caracas, Venezuela. On Friday, the acting President, Delcy Rodríguez, put the dead at 589 and the injured at 2,980. In La Guaira, the worst-hit State, over a hundred buildings crumbled to rubble. Geologically speaking, such destruction is, in Venezuela, an aberration. The country sits where the South American and Caribbean plates grind past one another, a boundary that slips sideways rather than thrusting upward – unlike the frequent quakes along the Pacific's Ring of Fire. Strain here accumulates quietly, over generations, before the ground settles its accounts in a single afternoon. It is early days, but seismologists have explained the twin quakes as a 'doublet,' what the US Geological Survey (USGS) calls a "complex rupture-interaction". Northern Venezuela saw a smaller doublet last year; the Türkiye-Syria earthquakes of 2023, which killed over 55,000 people, were of the same provenance. Their shallowness – under 30 kilometres – drove the fury straight into the streets above. The USGS has flagged a plausible toll exceeding 10,000, and the past is proof that such fears are likely to bear out rather than be refuted.

India, which has already offered help, should make relief its first duty – search teams, medical supplies, and the unglamorous logistics of a disaster zone. But there is a lesson here that it ought not to file away and forget. This year the Bureau of Indian Standards withdrew a decade's worth of commissioned work that found seismic hazard along the Himalayan front badly underestimated – a revision that nearly doubled design forces in the highest zones and added a sixth zone to a map that stopped at five. It was shelved after a Cabinet Secretariat order warned the standards "materially affected" ongoing infrastructure, metro projects among them. India's Zone V still designs for 0.36g, where g measures for how much the ground can shake. Pakistan and Nepal, on the same colliding front, reckon on nearly 0.75g, the United States and Japan on a full g or more. Nearly 79% of Indians live under moderate to severe seismic threat, and 95% of earthquake deaths occur in the one- to three-storey houses that no code ever reaches. Venezuela is a portent of the implicit danger that exists. The science of prediction will remain, for the foreseeable future, hope filling the gaps of uncertainty. What can be done is build structures that hold and keep their inhabitants safe. The earth follows its rhythm; the only choice is whether or not to be ready.

Whites on green

Wimbledon is keeping up with the changing times

No tournament marries old world charm with new age freshness quite like Wimbledon. This will be on display yet again when the year's third Major gets underway on Monday. If the pristine grass courts and all-white attire are reminders of tennis's origins and traditions, the introduction of video review technology from 2026 is the latest example of the event marching with the times. Another throwback to the old days will be the return of Serena Williams, a seven-time singles champion at the All England Club. She is 44, and has not played competitively in nearly four years, but appears leaner and fitter, thanks in large measure to modern-day weight-reduction medication. The legendary American is a wildcard entrant in doubles as well, where she will partner her illustrious sister and five-time Wimbledon singles winner Venus, with the duo looking for their seventh doubles crown at SW19. But unranked as Serena is, the probability of meeting high-profile opponents from the get-go is high. Women's tennis is also a crowded market-place, with as many as five Slam champions and three others with runner-up finishes among the top-10 seeds. Chief among them are World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka, 2022 winner Elena Rybakina, defending champion Iga Swiatek and the teenaged Mirra Andreeva, who clinched her maiden Major at Roland-Garros recently.

The men's section will be equally intriguing. Carlos Alcaraz, a two-time Wimbledon titlist and a fan-favourite in south-west London, is absent because of a wrist injury. Reigning champion Jan-nik Sinner suffered a dispiriting second-round loss at the French Open and has had no competitive matches since then. The defeat in Paris came under extremely hot conditions, and with western Europe in the midst of a heatwave, it will be interesting to see how the Italian World No. 1 copes. Second seed Alexander Zverev will look to cash in, like he did at Roland-Garros, but grass is his weakest surface. This presents Novak Djokovic with his best chance to claim a record-extending 25th Slam. At 39, the lush green lawn is where the Serb is most comfortable. With four trophies, two finals and one semifinal appearance in his last seven visits to Wimbledon, he is also the most pedigree. However, for a second straight Major, there is likely to be an unpleasant backdrop with leading players set to expand their protest at what they deem as an inadequate increase in prize money (less than 22% of the tournament revenue). Actions at the biggest competitions do garner attention but they also benefit the elite players more than the rank and file. Tennis needs an equitable solution for the betterment of all. If the argument of the top players is that the organisers keep most of the revenue, then it can also be said that they earn disproportionately more than their lower-ranked peers. The gap between the haves and have-nots is only widening.

For over a decade, the Narendra Modi government has projected India as the world's fastest-growing major economy, an emerging manufacturing hub, a Vishwaguru, a global power, a preferred destination for global capital, and a Viksit Bharat on track for 2047. Yet, behind this carefully crafted narrative lies a more troubling reality. The economy faces multiple external shocks while carrying deep structural weaknesses that threaten its long-term prospects.

The warning signs are unmistakable. But instead of addressing them, the ruling establishment appears more focused on manufactured controversies, communal polarisation and divisive politics. As television studios debate temples, mosques, medieval rulers and invented enemies, the economy's foundations continue to weaken.

Imported energy, growing risks

The most immediate challenge is India's growing vulnerability to external shocks. The country imports nearly 90% of its crude oil and about half of its natural gas requirements. Every rise in global energy prices is quickly transmitted to the domestic economy. The recent rise in fuel prices underscores a stark reality: despite the rhetoric of renewable energy, self-reliance and global leadership, India remains heavily dependent on imported energy.

The consequences are severe. Rising oil and liquefied natural gas prices widen the trade deficit, weaken the rupee and raise production costs across the economy. In FY2025-26, the Reserve Bank of India sold over \$53 billion in the foreign exchange market to support the rupee – its largest intervention in more than a decade. Foreign exchange reserves have fallen from over \$720 billion to around \$681 billion. An economy with strong fundamentals should not have to spend such vast sums merely to slow its currency's decline. The issue is politically significant as well. Narendra Modi, as Gujarat Chief Minister, often linked the rupee's value to national pride. Today, despite that rhetoric, the rupee has fallen to a historic low of about ₹95 against the U.S. dollar.

Compounding the problem is the uncertainty surrounding fertilizers and agriculture. Again, India's apparent strength in manufacturing fertilizers masks a dangerous vulnerability. Domestic urea production depends heavily on imported LNG. Almost all the fertilizers India produce are linked to heavy imports such as LNG and potash. Any disruption in global gas supplies, any sharp increase in LNG prices or supply chain disruption immediately threatens fertilizer availability and affordability.

The challenge is compounded by the monsoon outlook. A weak monsoon affects far more than agriculture. Lower crop yields reduce rural incomes, weaken consumption, fuel food inflation. They also increase the need for government spending on relief, procurement and



D. Raja

General Secretary,
Communist Party
of India (CPI)

Behind the government's carefully crafted narrative, India's economic vulnerabilities continue to deepen

subsidies, which is unlikely under the Bharatiya Janata Party's rule. These risks reinforce one another. Rising fuel costs, expensive fertilizers and a weak monsoon together create a vicious cycle that suppresses demand when the economy needs stronger domestic consumption.

Weakening rural safety nets

A responsible government would respond by strengthening employment guarantees and social protection. Instead, the Modi government abolished the Planning Commission and has steadily weakened MGNREGA, one of the country's most effective rural safety nets. As a result, millions of rural households now face greater economic uncertainty with fewer protections than they had a decade ago.

Beyond these immediate pressures lies a deeper structural concern. India's external sector remains heavily dependent on services exports and remittances. The record \$135 billion in remittances received in FY2024-25 has been a key factor in financing the current account deficit.

Even this strength carries a warning. Increasingly, India's remittances come not from migrant workers in West Asia but from highly skilled professionals in the United States, the United Kingdom and other advanced economies. The rise of right-wing politics and anti-immigration sentiment – championed by leaders such as U.S. President Donald Trump and echoed across much of the West – poses a growing threat to this model. At the same time, artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming software, data processing and other professional services in which Indian workers have traditionally excelled.

The danger is not that remittances will disappear overnight, but that one of the pillars supporting India's external balance could gradually weaken. If remittance growth slows while energy imports remain high, pressure on the current account and the rupee will intensify.

International investors are already turning cautious. Foreign portfolio investors have withdrawn over ₹2.2 lakh crore from Indian equities this year, while India has slipped from sixth to seventh in global market-capitalisation rankings. Domestic retail investors have limited the damage, but the message is clear: global investors are becoming less convinced by India's growth story.

Even more worrying is India's position in the technological transformation currently reshaping the global economy. Mr. Modi's hollow guarantees have not only weakened what was built earlier but also his diversionary politics has prevented a discussion on what the future would be like and what India's role in it would be.

The 21st century will be defined by AI, semiconductors, advanced manufacturing, robotics and frontier science. Yet, India remains largely absent from these strategic sectors. Although the country has a vibrant startup ecosystem, much of it is concentrated in digital

India-New Zealand FTA, a modern trade partnership

For years, trade between India and New Zealand has been a relationship with untapped potential. The two economies have remained friendly partners, yet commercial engagement has never quite matched the opportunities available. Trade remains relatively modest. The bilateral merchandise trade stood at \$1.3 billion (approximately) in FY 2024-25, of which India's exports to New Zealand accounted for only around \$711 million, despite registering 32% year-on-year growth. The numbers are moving in the right direction, but remain small when compared to India's trade relationships with larger partners. The proposed India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) could change that equation as it attempts to create conditions for faster bilateral growth.

At first glance, the headlines are easy to focus on – zero-duty access for Indian exports, wider market access for services, and a proposed investment commitment of \$20 billion over the next 15 years. These are important outcomes. The larger story, however, is that the agreement reflects the evolving nature of trade partnerships.

Modern trade beyond tariffs

Modern FTAs are no longer just about lowering customs duties. Businesses today are equally concerned about how quickly goods move through ports, how easily certifications are recognised, whether regulations are predictable, and how much compliance effort is required to access preferential treatment. In many industries, these factors influence competitiveness as much as tariffs.

For Indian exports, New Zealand has extended duty-free access across 100% of its tariff lines. However, for businesses, particularly in labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, apparel, leather, and handicrafts, this is not merely a



Aditya Nadkarni

Director, Indirect Tax,
Nexdigm



Snehal Gadhave

Senior Manager,
Indirect Tax, Nexdigm

It is a strategic trade pact with long-term economic potential

removal of duties that had earlier reached to 10%, but a clear pricing advantage in a market otherwise dominated by established FTA partners. In a market where competing exporters already enjoy preferential access, even a single-digit tariff advantage can influence purchasing decisions.

On the other hand, India's approach is cautious. Sensitive sectors such as dairy have remained protected, reflecting a policy preference that has become increasingly visible in India's recent trade negotiations. The objective is clear: open and explore new opportunities without exposing vulnerable domestic industries to competitors.

Services could emerge as one of the most significant beneficiaries over the longer term. Indian businesses have strong capabilities in technology, consulting, engineering, health care, and education services. Greater market access along with clearer mobility provisions for professionals and students can make it easier for Indian firms to expand their presence in New Zealand. For a country where services account for an increasing share of economic output, these provisions deserve as much attention as tariff concessions.

Compliance unlocks trade benefits

One more feature that businesses should watch closely is the Rules of Origin (RoO) framework. Preferential access under an FTA is never automatic. Companies must demonstrate that products meet prescribed origin requirements before claiming lower duties. The India-New Zealand agreement incorporates detailed product-specific rules, documentation requirements, and traceability measures to prevent misuse through transshipment.

From a policy standpoint, this strengthens the

intermediation rather than technological innovation. Food delivery, ride-hailing and quick-commerce platforms may create high valuations, but they do not build technological sovereignty. Many of India's celebrated startups still depend on organising abundant low-cost labour through digital platforms rather than developing globally competitive technologies.

The contrast with global leaders here is striking. Taiwan dominates advanced semiconductor manufacturing through TSMC. South Korea commands critical positions through Samsung. The U.S. and China lead in AI, advanced chips and foundational technologies. India possesses immense engineering talent but remains heavily dependent on imported semiconductors, imported technology and imported capital equipment. Despite years of slogans about innovation and self-reliance, the country remains a marginal player in the industries that will define the future.

Scant transformation

This is perhaps the most serious indictment of the Modi decade. The promised manufacturing revolution has not materialised. The demographic dividend remains unutilised. Millions of young people continue to confront precarious employment, stagnant wages and shrinking opportunities.

Every failure has been passed on to ordinary people with a dose of hyper-nationalism. Wealth and opportunity continue to concentrate in fewer hands. The burden is socialised; the benefits are privatised.

Electoral victories should not be mistaken for economic success. A government can win elections while pursuing policies that weaken the long-term foundations of economic development.

The tragedy of contemporary India is that while the economy sends increasingly urgent distress signals, public attention is repeatedly diverted towards communal polarisation and manufactured controversies. Citizens are encouraged to fear one another rather than question policies that affect their livelihoods.

India possesses the resources, talent and productive capacity to chart a different path. But doing so requires confronting the policies that have brought the country to this point. It requires defending public investment, strengthening social protection, rebuilding employment generation, investing in science and technology, reducing external dependence and restoring economic priorities to the centre of public life.

Above all, it requires a resolute and united struggle against policies that enrich a few corporates while burdening millions with poverty. The choice before the country is stark: continue down the present path of division and economic fragility, or build a broad democratic movement with left-of-centre economics, capable of defending livelihoods, jobs and the future itself. The time to wake up is now, before it is too late.

integrity of the agreement, while from a business standpoint; it raises the importance of supply chain visibility and compliance readiness.

The same principle applies to trade facilitation measures included in the pact. Faster customs clearances, digital certification systems, and simplified procedures often deliver tangible commercial benefits. Reduced delays can reduce inventory costs, improve cash flow, and create greater certainty across supply chains.

This agreement also aims to address non-tariff barriers, particularly in sectors where regulatory approvals often matter more than tariffs. Industries such as pharmaceuticals, food processing, chemicals, and agriculture could gain benefits if regulatory processes are streamlined and more predictable.

Preparing businesses for FTAs

Viewed more broadly, the agreement marks another step in India's transition towards a facilitation-led trade policy, where businesses enhance competitiveness not only through lower tariffs but also through reduced transaction costs, faster market access, and greater certainty across the trade ecosystem.

From a business perspective, the real opportunity lies not merely in availing lower duties but also in integrating operational, sourcing, and compliance functions with the framework of the agreement. Today, preferential access increasingly depends on demonstrable compliance, traceability, and process discipline. Given this, businesses should proactively review Harmonised System (HS) classifications, evaluate eligibility under the RoO framework, strengthen supply-chain documentation, identify sector-specific export opportunities, and reassess landed-cost models to maximise the commercial advantages offered under the agreement.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Passport and citizenship

As in the Passports Act, 1967, a passport is defined as a travel document intended to regulate the departure from India of citizens and others. However, the practice of issuing passports that indicate the holder's nationality, often without thorough authentication or verification, raises serious

concerns about administrative responsibility. This issue is not confined to passports alone. The authorities responsible for issuing a ration card, Aadhaar card, PAN card, and voter ID card also routinely record nationality details without adequate verification. Such practices could be seen as a dereliction of duty,

particularly given the substantial public funds allocated to these processes. The question that arises is: where does the fault lie? Is it with government authorities or with the people? This issue deserves urgent legal and public scrutiny. **A. Mariafrancis,** Chennai

A passport in India is not issued casually. If the state itself has carried out these stringent checks, questioning a person's citizenship later creates a contradiction. Many Indians, especially those from older generations, may not have preserved their birth certificates or ancestral records. For them, a

passport is often the highest official proof of identity and nationality they possess. If even that is open to doubt, proving citizenship becomes significantly more difficult. The controversy comes amid the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls and ongoing citizenship verification exercises. A sovereign state must ensure

that the documents it issues inspire certainty and public confidence. If a passport cannot conclusively establish citizenship, the government owes citizens a clear and straightforward explanation.

Gregory Fernandes, Mumbai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



Fire personnel conduct a dousing operation at the commercial building in Aliganj, Lucknow. PTI

The rules that failed 15 lives in Lucknow

On June 22, a fire broke out in a building in Uttar Pradesh's capital city, claiming 15 lives, most of them students and staff of an animation centre. According to eyewitnesses, bystanders, and survivors, the building lacked basic fire safety systems. **Mayank Kumar** reports on the tragedy and the regulatory gaps it exposes amid rapid urbanisation in India's most populous State

For 26-year-old Rishabh Mishra, the images of the afternoon of June 22 will always haunt him – people jumping from a burning building or clinging to live wires in an attempt to survive. One in particular refuses to fade: a man pleading from a window, his face flushed and his eyes desperately seeking help as flames raged behind him.

It was around 2:30 p.m. when Mishra, a bystander, noticed the fire in a three-storey commercial building in Sector D in Aliganj, Lucknow. The building housed a pet shop and a clinic on the ground and first floor, a video gaming zone and 3D art and design animation centre named Head Hoppers Studio on the second floor, and an IT networking office on the third floor.

Mishra says he immediately swung into action. “I made two trips to the King George’s Medical University (KGMU) – once by car and once by ambulance – ferrying injured people,” he says.

Despite having gone to the hospital twice, a visibly exhausted Mishra cannot recall the route when he gets ready to go the third time, this time on his bike. “I was just focused on getting people there. I didn’t notice the way,” he says. Taking a sip of water from a bottle for the first time after nearly three hours, he asks a police constable how to get to the premier medical institute, 5 kilometres away.

The fire claimed 15 lives, most of them students and staff of the animation centre, while nine others sustained injuries and were admitted to the KGMU Trauma Centre. As per the post-mortem reports, the 15 of them did not have major burn injuries; they suffocated to death.

On the same day, the Uttar Pradesh government formed a two-member Special Investigation Team to conduct an impartial and time-bound investigation into the fire incident. The team has been instructed to submit its report within seven days.

The Lucknow fire is yet another addition to India’s summer of fire tragedies. Early this month, a fire in a bed-and-breakfast took the lives of 23 people in South Delhi’s Malviya Nagar; last month, nine people were killed in a major fire which broke out at a residential building in Shahdara in East Delhi. In all these incidents, violations of safety guidelines and administrative negligence have been the causes.

No room to escape

A First Information Report filed by the Uttar Pradesh police says that a short circuit may have originated in the air conditioning duct on the first floor or the pet shop located on the ground floor.

According to Abhishek Pandey, an eyewitness who tried to enter the building but was forced to retreat due to the clouds of smoke, the fire spread rapidly across the upper floors. “There were no emergency exits. The only staircase in the building was obstructed by the thick smoke.



There were no emergency exits. The only staircase in the building was obstructed by thick smoke

ABHISHEK PANDEY
Eyewitness

Some people took refuge in washrooms to evade the fire,” says Pandey.

A survivor says the digital lock of the animation centre was non-functional amid a power shortage. This left students and staff trapped. He adds that the route to the roof was blocked, forcing some people to leap in panic from windows.

Pandey says it took firefighters at least 30 minutes to reach the spot. “Firefighters, police, and SDRF (State Disaster Response Force) personnel arrived to discover that there was no space for evacuation. Unable to access the main entrances, rescue teams had to breach the walls of the building to extract bodies,” he says. Nineteen firefighting vehicles extinguished the fire in about four hours, according to records of the Lucknow Fire and Emergency Services accessed by *The Hindu*.

Anamika Samanta, an animation artist with three years of experience at Head Hoppers Studio, and Nilesch Kumar were among the 15 people who died in the fire. The two of them were in love and were engaged to be married.

Anamika’s father, Vishwanath Samanta, who lives in West Bengal, is devastated. While collecting her body from the post-mortem facility at KGMU, he weails in anguish. “Our family is shattered,” he says, adding that his wife repeatedly fainted on hearing the news.

Nilesch’s family is distraught too, he says. “We had visited his house 2-3 times earlier,” says Samanta. “We had also met his parents.”

He last spoke to his daughter on the morning of the incident. “She told me, ‘I am going to work now.’ That is the last time I heard her voice.”

Sagar, a 3D artist in training at the institute, was another victim. His friend Rahul Singh rushed to Aliganj after receiving a call from a mutual friend. “Sagar had called my friend and begged him to save him. I reached the spot in 15 minutes, but I could not enter the studio,” he says. “I pleaded with the authorities to drag my friend out. But they told us that they were unable to access the main entrances. Rescue teams had to enter the building from neighbouring buildings to pull out trapped victims. That took a lot of

time. Precious time was wasted and my friend died,” says Singh, bursting into tears at the entrance of the post-mortem house in Lucknow.

The Aliganj pet shop and clinic sold pet food, accessories, and habitat supplies and also provided medical and surgical care for pets. It advised owners on the right food and products based on their pets’ breed and age. At least 25 pets, including cats and dogs, were inside the shop when the fire broke out.

“When we received information about the fire on our helpline, our seven-member team reached the spot within 20 minutes. Many animal lovers also gathered at the fire site,” says Shubham Pratap Singh, a member of Jeev Aashraya Foundation, a Lucknow-based NGO that rescues and rehabilitates pet animals. “We pushed for the immediate rescue of pets as cats and dogs are vulnerable to fire disasters due to their inability to adjust to high temperatures. After our efforts, more than 10 cats and dogs were handed over to us. We kept them for a few hours in the house of a man called Vishal Melhotra, who allowed us to use the AC in his house as well. Sadly, some cats who were on the first floor died in the fire.”

Flouting rules

The building where the fire broke out was being used for commercial purposes even though it had been approved by the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) only for residential use, show the Lucknow Fire and Emergency Services records. According to the FIR, the building also lacked basic fire safety measures, including emergency exits, smoke ventilation systems, fire extinguishers, and other fire protection features.

The building, spread over about 1,992 square feet, was owned by Virendra Pratap Shukla and Surendra Pratap Shukla from January 2013. The LDA approved a residential building plan for the property in 2014 under its self-certification scheme, under which a licensed architect or engineer certifies that the building plan complies with local building bylaws. However, officials later found unauthorised construction on the premises and registered a case against Virendra Pratap Shukla in 2016. Following an investigation, the LDA ordered the illegal portions to be demolished on May 10, 2016, but revoked the order less than two months later, on July 5, raising questions about why the decision was reversed.

An enquiry by the LDA into the incident found 18 officials and engineers of the Authority, many of them retired now, guilty of regulatory lapses linked to the building.

So far, four people – Virendra Pratap Shukla, the owner; and Suresh Kumar Sahu, Ramkrishna Upadhyay, and Tushak Krishna Jaiswal, all of them tenants occupying different floors of the building – have been arrested. They were booked under Sections 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), 110 (attempt to commit culpable homicide), and 125 (rash or negligent act endangering human life) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, and provisions of the Uttar Pradesh Fire and Emergency Services Act, 2022. Four officials – Gaurav Kumar, Executive Engineer (Collection), Jankipuram; Kamleendra Kumar Singh, Fire Station Second Officer, Indira Nagar; Anil Kumar, Assistant Engineer; and Pramod Pandey, Junior Engineer – have been suspended.

Singh issued a statement accusing higher officers of making him a scapegoat and demanded that Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath fix accountability on the Lucknow chief fire officer for the lapses linked to the incident. He sought a review of the disciplinary action taken against him. Later, he retracted his statement.

Inspection drive

Following the fire, the LDA launched a citywide inspection drive on June 23 to identify and take

action against buildings and establishments operating in violation of safety and building regulations. They sealed 71 establishments and issued notices to 83 building owners/managers on the first day of inspection.

An LDA official said, “This campaign, conducted on the instructions of LDA Vice President Prathamesh Kumar, in collaboration with a joint team of the fire department and the Lucknow police, has targeted dozens of coaching centres, libraries, dance studios, playgroup schools, blood banks, computer institutes, nursing homes, hotels, commercial complexes, and other establishments.” Officials also took similar action in other parts of the State. They say they will carry out the campaign for three weeks.

The U.P. government also directed all the District Magistrates to conduct a comprehensive survey of all the coaching institutes operating in their respective districts to ensure compliance with safety standards. The inspection includes aspects such as building arrangements, fire safety, electrical safety, and other necessary facilities.

Yogendra Upadhyay, Higher Education Minister in the State government, said in an official statement, “All District Magistrates have been directed to conduct a comprehensive survey of all coaching institutes operating in their respective districts and prepare a list. Strict action, as per rules, is being ensured against institutions that are not registered under the Uttar Pradesh Coaching Regulation Act, 2002.... Any kind of irregularity or negligence will not be tolerated.”

The opposition Samajwadi Party (SP) criticised the government and administrative authorities. “The safety of students and citizens is paramount. But initiating a sudden drive after such a tragedy... shows an attempt to hide failure and corruption,” said Uday Veer Singh, an SP spokesperson. “Safety shouldn’t be compromised. Why was the government asleep for the past 10 years? Where did the government get so much staff in a single day to issue notices to thousands of people across the State after conducting inspections?”

Singh said a massive fire in April had damaged a labourers’ settlement near Sector-12 in Vikas Nagar, Lucknow. “We had demanded strict implementation of safety protocols then too, but no action was taken,” he said.

The way forward

Vineet Singh, a police officer in the State police force, who spent a decade serving in Lucknow, suggests a practical approach to the crisis. Many buildings were constructed decades earlier when upgraded safety protocols were not in place, he says. “We need to retrofit old buildings with modern fire safety solutions. There may be structural limitations as some older structures were not designed to house modern systems such as smoke detectors or sprinklers, but wireless fire alarms are ideal for retrofits as they reduce extensive wiring challenges,” he says.

Singh adds that sprinkler retrofits can use flexible systems, which are easier to install in tight spaces. “Fire-resistant coatings can be applied to structural elements without altering the appearance, and retrofitted fire doors with self-closing mechanisms can improve evacuation safety,” Singh says. “We need to develop retrofit plans that balance safety standards with architectural preservation.”

In older buildings, emergency evacuation can be improved by upgrading to LED exit signs and photoluminescent wayfinding markings. Around the world, many retrofit projects also involve installing wireless fire alarm and sprinkler systems in multi-storey residential buildings constructed decades ago without modern fire safety measures, he adds.

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A man breaks down on hearing the news about a loved one's death. ANI

From Page One

Ayodhya fund case:
eight in judicial custody

The FIR was registered on Thursday, after a preliminary investigation by a Special Investigation Team.

Uttar Pradesh Opposition parties claimed that, while the FIR accused trust employees, the real bigwigs behind the alleged scam – such as Mr. Champat Rai, fellow SRJTK trustee Anil Mishra, and temple construction in-charge Gopal Rao – have been protected by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

“We will launch a campaign against this massive corruption and attempt to protect powerful people,” said U.P. Congress chief Ajay Rai.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath vowed to enforce accountability. “Tampering with people’s faith cannot be tolerated. As soon as the SIT report was received, action was initiated immediately,” he said. “I assure you, and I had said this earlier as well, that we will separate truth from falsehood. Whoever tampers with the faith of the people will have to face the consequences. No one can be given such a free hand.” He insisted that no “aspersions” should be cast on the sacred town of Ayodhya or its reigning deity.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Hindu Group has been named the ‘Champion Publisher of the Year 2026’ by the World Association of News Publishers (WAN-IFRA), earning the title for the third time. The Group topped the table with seven awards at the WAN-IFRA Digital Media Awards South Asia 2026.

The title is awarded to the publisher securing the highest number of wins at the annual awards, which recognise outstanding digital projects demonstrating innovation, audience engagement, journalistic excellence, and the effective use of technology.

The Hindu won a gold each for ‘Bihar SIR’ in the ‘Best AI-driven News Product, Format or Strategy’ category and ‘Young World Club’ in ‘Best News Web-



The Hindu Group members pose with the awards alongside other winners at the WAN-IFRA event in New Delhi. R.V. MOORTHY

site or App Relaunch’. It also secured a silver for ‘Written by Journalists’ in ‘Best in Countering Disinformation’. Additionally, the publication took home three bronze awards: ‘Made of Chennai’ for ‘Best Marketing Campaign for a News Brand’, ‘The Hindu

Explains’ for ‘Best Newsletter’, and ‘We Went Middle East, Talked INR, and Found Gold!’ for ‘Best Reader Revenue’.

Frontline won a bronze for ‘Mission Manipur’ in the ‘Best Use of Audio’ category, taking The Hindu Group’s overall tally to se-

ven awards.

Competing with media houses across South Asia, *The Hindu* was among the winners alongside HT Media Labs, Reuters, The Quint, Jagran News Media, *Malayala Manorama*, *Financial Times*, and others.

The Hindu Group CEO

L.V. Navaneeth received the ‘Champion Publisher of the Year 2026’ award from WAN-IFRA leaders – Chief Operating Officer Thomas Jacob, Chief Executive Officer Stig Orskov, and Managing Director (South Asia) Magdooom Mohamed at the Digital Media

India 2026 Conference in Delhi on Thursday.

“Our goal has always been to strive for the highest standards of journalistic excellence and ethics. It is heartening to receive recognition for that work. Winning this honour for the third time shows that every member of The Hindu Group is doing something right,” Mr. Navaneeth said.

WAN-IFRA is the world’s largest international news media organisation, representing 3,000 news publishing companies and technology entrepreneurs, along with 40 publisher associations representing 18,000 publications across 120 countries.

The Digital Media Awards South Asia 2026 comprised 12 categories, with entries judged by digital media experts, editors, and industry leaders.

India’s eastern borders affected by
flow of opium from Myanmar: NCB

Neighbouring country emerges as alternative global opium source after ban on drugs in Afghanistan, says bureau; India’s eastern borders through Manipur corridor are the most direct and porous entry point for this expanding production base

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Illegal trade: Myanmar’s illicit opium cultivation expanded by approximately 56% between 2021 and 2023. AP

Following the 2022 Taliban-imposed ban on drugs in Afghanistan, Myanmar has emerged as an alternative source of global opium supply and the consequences are already visible along India’s eastern borders, through the Manipur corridor, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) said in its 2026 annual report.

The report, released on Friday by Home Minister Amit Shah, highlighted the fact that the northeastern States of Manipur, Mizoram, and Nagaland are bearing the sharpest frontline exposure due to the enhanced production of drugs in Myanmar.

Porous border

Porous border mechanisms, including the Free Movement Regime (FMR) along the India-Myanmar border, have created conditions under which these States have transitioned from peripheral transit zones to active staging grounds for distribution of narcotics into the Indian hinterland.

Myanmar’s illicit opium cultivation expanded by approximately 56% between 2021 and 2023, according to the NCB report, with the area under poppy cultivation reaching 45,200 hectares.

India’s eastern borders through the Manipur corridor are the most direct and porous entry point for this expanding production base, the report said.

“Myanmar’s Golden Triangle has expanded as both an opiate supplier and a dominant methamphetamine (Yaba tablets) hub. The convergence, primarily in areas controlled by ethnic armed groups in Shan State, has created a poly-drug production. The Manipur corridor, through

which India’s National Highway no. 102 passes, is the primary land entry point for both heroin and methamphetamine tablets,” it said.

The second major trafficking corridor enters India through Champhai in Mizoram, which shares close proximity with Myanmar’s Chin State.

Drugs are smuggled through unfenced and porous stretches of the border and routed towards Silchar in Assam’s Barak Valley through Aizawl and adjoining road networks, the report added.

In 2025, Mizoram accounted for 1,477 kg of seized amphetamine-type stimulants, out of total seizures amounting to 3,485

kg across the country. The other States where such recoveries were reported are Manipur (535 kg), Delhi (454 kg), Gujarat (308 kg) and Karnataka (164 kg).

Drone-based trafficking

On the other side of the country, despite the Taliban’s 2022 crackdown, which reduced Afghan opium production by 93% from its peak, around 13,200 tonnes of pre-ban narcotics are sustaining the trafficking pipelines and making their way into India through the western border.

The NCB said that drone-based drug trafficking from across the Pakistan border has seen a five-fold increase over the past five years, particularly into Punjab.

In 2025, there were 305 such cases, resulting in the seizure of 468 kg of narcotics, a 96% increase in quantity over 2024. Punjab alone accounted for 298 such cases and 461 kg seized, primarily heroin (449.751 kg) and methamphetamine (9.018 kg). Overall, Punjab accounted for 58% of total seizures, which amounted to 3,567

kg across the country.

“The scale of this threat is underscored by the growth trajectory: from just 3 incidents in 2021, incidents surged to 35 in 2022, 28 in 2023, before accelerating sharply to 178 incidents in 2024 and 305 incidents in 2025, a 100-fold increase in incident count over five years,” the report said.

This exponential rise reflects the growing operational maturity of trafficking networks using unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) to circumvent traditional border controls, the NCB said. Additional incidents were reported in Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir.

“The South Asian arm [of the drug trade via Afghanistan] flows through Pakistan into India via both the land frontier in Punjab and Rajasthan, and the maritime frontier along the Gujarat and Maharashtra coastlines, the latter a route of increasing concern given its use of fishing vessels and coastal craft that operate below the detection threshold of standard maritime surveillance,” the NCB said.

Amendments to anti-drug
law will address emerging
challenges, says Amit Shah

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Friday that the Department of Revenue would amend the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and asked States to submit suggestions to address existing loopholes.

The NDPS Act and Rules will be updated to address emerging challenges and regulatory gaps while promoting a more reformative approach towards persons consuming drugs or suffering from addiction, according to the ‘Vision Document on Drug Control (2026-2029)’ released by Mr. Shah. He said that the entire road map had been prepared on the foundation of “detect, disrupt and destroy”, and urged the State governments to target drug traffickers and gangsters hiding abroad, through Red Corner Notices with the help of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

He addressed the 10th apex-level meeting of the Narco-Coordination Centre (NCORD) organised by the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB).



Home Minister Amit Shah releases the vision document on narcotics control during the 10th apex-level meeting of the NCB. PTI

He said that the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) was working towards establishing exclusive NDPS courts to ensure speedy convictions in major cases. The entire process of identifying proceeds of crime, freezing them, seizing them, and ensuring they do not return to the accused will have to be made evidence-based and equipped with modern technology, the Minister said.

Releasing the vision document, he said that the next three years will decide “whether addiction will defeat us or we will defeat addiction”.

The document provides a time-bound national strategy to substantially dismantle the narcotics-drug

ecosystem through coordinated action against trafficking, abuse, illicit finance and organised criminal networks.

More than 40 Ministries, Central agencies, State governments, district administrations, educational institutions, civil society organisations and citizens will work together under a common national framework against drugs. Enforcement efforts will shift from targeting individual carriers to identifying, investigating and dismantling complete drug trafficking networks, the document stated.

It also called for AI-enabled profiling to strengthen interdiction capabilities across land, sea and air trafficking routes.

Four Odisha officials
suspended for errors
in school textbooks

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha government on Friday placed four senior officers including former director of State Council of Education, Research and Training (SCERT) Manoj Padhi under suspension and took disciplinary action against six persons holding them responsible for over 2,000 mistakes in textbooks being taught in Classes 1 to 8.

The action was taken following the submission of an inquiry report by a committee constituted under the chairmanship of the Development Commissioner to examine errors in school textbooks. While teachers pointed out errors totalling over 2,100 in textbooks printed for the 2026-27 academic year, the government acknowledged 1,678 mistakes.

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi issued directions for the sus-

pension of Mr. Padhi along with three assistant directors – Pralipta Mishra, Dilip Kumar Sahu, and Bharati Tudu. Moreover, disciplinary actions have been initiated against six assistant directors.

Quality Assurance Cell

“The SCERT will prepare a Master Errata Register and provide corrected information to all students, and establish a Quality Assurance Cell,” the CMO said.

“The government will provide replacement pages or reprinted inserts for serious errors. After rectifying mistakes online, the corrected PDF will be declared as the official teaching version. Conduct of immediate correction orientation for teachers has been recommended,” the statement said.

The panel recommended issue of show-cause notices and action against the DTP agency, printer, and approving authority.

Students of CBSE Classes 7 to 9 can
learn two foreign languages for now

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

Students studying in Classes 7, 8 and 9 in Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) affiliated schools can continue learning foreign languages under the three-language policy until Class 10, sources in the Ministry of Education stated on Friday.

The clarification comes over a month after CBSE stated that students in Class 9 must study three languages, of which two should be native to India, from July 1 in the 2026-27 academic year.

This led to CBSE schools instructing their students who had opted for foreign languages like French, German, Spanish and so on to switch to a native language, in case they are already studying English.

There are at least six lakh students who study French and 1.5 lakh students who study German in all schools across India



The CBSE is expected to reverse its May 15 circular which had mandated at least two Indian languages for Class 9 students. PTI

spread across various grades, including CBSE schools.

Strong pushback

An official spokesperson from the German Embassy confirmed that the diplomatic mission is in touch with the Government of India over the issue.

Sources also stated that there had been a pushback by German and French Embassies against the Centre’s three-language formula which will gra-

dually lead to phasing out of foreign language teaching from CBSE schools by 2030-31, if not sooner.

Sources have clarified that the three-language formula will apply to students entering Class 6 who will have to study three languages, two of which will be native to India.

The CBSE circular led to protests from parents, students and teachers, who had approached Supreme Court against the abrupt switch, arguing that stu-

dents in Class 9 who have already studied a foreign language for the past three to four years will find it very difficult to suddenly switch their language option.

CBSE is expected to reverse its May 15 circular which had mandated a three-language formula under the National Education Policy to be applied to Class 9 students, the sources added.

The clarification comes over a week after the Supreme Court refused to grant interim relief on petitions challenging the implementation of CBSE’s three-language policy for Class 9 students in 2026-27.

It is expected that CBSE will withdraw the latest circular in light of the controversy and will direct schools to gradually implement the three-language policy over five consecutive academic years up to 2030-31, rather than rolling it out for all classes from 2026-27.

Drugs on credit is
pushing substance
abuse in Manipur: CM

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Drug traffickers not only changed their routes in Manipur after the ethnic conflict erupted in May 2023 but they also adopted a credit policy to push consumption during troubled times, Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh said on Friday.

Addressing an event organised by the State’s Social Welfare Department to mark the International Day against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking, he said, many youth in Manipur started using heroin and other drugs in the 1970s.

“At that time, heroin was extremely expensive, and it was largely affordable only to the children from rich families. But things have changed now,” he said.

Manipur used to be a major conduit for heroin, methamphetamine, and other synthetic drugs via

Moreh, a town on the India-Myanmar border.

Mr. Singh said the routes for drug trafficking changed significantly after the ethnic crisis began in 2023.

Mizoram route

“Trafficking of drugs has largely been diverted through Mizoram, while smaller quantities continue to be routed from Moreh to Churachandpur via roads constructed under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana,” he said.

He added that the nearest point for distributing drugs after they reach Churachandpur is Khatka.

Citing Kwatka-based civil society organisations, Mr. Singh said almost 70% of the youth in the area were indulging in drugs. “The drug peddlers often allow users to purchase drugs on credit. This practice has made the drug users get easy access to drugs,” he said.

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday assured the family of Ketan Agarwal, who was allegedly pushed to death from Lohagad Fort by his fiancée and her lover, that the government would ensure strict punishment to those responsible and spare no effort in securing justice. Mr. Fadnavis also accepted the Agarwal family's demand to try the case in a fast-track court. Ketan's father, Vishal Agarwal, met the Chief Minister in Pune and sought justice for his son. Ketan's fiancée Siya Goyal (20) and her lover Chetan Chaudhary (22) are accused of pushing Ketan off a cliff at Lohagad Fort, located in Maval taluka of Pune district, on June 18. PTI

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Muharram processions were held across the Kashmir Valley on Friday to mark Ashura. The solemn day commemorates the martyrdom of Hussain the grandson of Prophet Muhammad - who was killed in the Battle of Karbala in the 7th century.

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah joined the mourners. Leaders of Opposition parties also joined the processions.

The mourners assembled early in the morning at Srinagar's Gulshan Bagh and took part in the processions leading up to Zaidib in the old city. The mourners marched through the streets as they wailed and performed chest-beating in a show of grief.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A fatal scuffle over a ₹500 watch between neighbours led to a nearly 30-year-old criminal case, which finally drew to an end in the Supreme Court due to death, old age and exhaustion.

A Bench headed by Justice Ujjal Bhuyan closed criminal proceedings in the culpable homicide case after noting that two of the three accused have died during the pendency of the appeal, the remaining one was well over 60 years of age and it has been three weary decades of litigation since the deceased, Padam Singh, fell into a dry canal during the scuffle and died from his injuries.

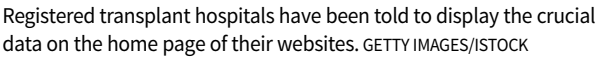
The judgment was based on an appeal filed by the surviving accused, Mathu, against an Uttarakhand High Court judgment of July 2012.

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Union Health and Family Welfare Ministry has asked the State governments to direct registered organ transplant hospitals to reveal post-transplant survival data and publish the same on their respective websites.

The data are being collected for the first time on such a scale to reveal the success rate of transplant surgeries, especially kidney, lung and heart transplants, and lifespan of those who have received the organs. The results are expected to enable patients requiring transplants to take a decision or make a choice. The hospitals are told to strictly adhere to informed consent requirements and ensure that all relevant information regarding transplant procedures, risks, and outcomes is adequately disclosed to patients and their families.

In a note to the Health Secretaries of the States and Union Territories, the National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation



(NOTTO), which functions under the Directorate-General of Health Services, referred to a letter written by Dakshina Kannada MP Bri-jesh Chawta on the need to enhance transparency and accountability of kidney transplantation outcomes. The MP had emphasised the need for tracking long-term transplant outcomes, including graft survival, complications, and mortality, as well as disclosure of post-transplant survival data by hospitals and strict adherence to informed consent and patient communication protocols. The NOTTO maintains

the National Organ and Tissue Transplant Registry, which includes data of kidney donors and recipients. Its Director, Anil Kumar, said in the note that regular and comprehensive reporting of post-transplant data would strengthen monitoring of transplant outcomes, improve traceability, and support evidence-based policy decisions.

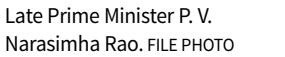
Boosting transparency

Registered transplant hospitals across the country were told to display the crucial data on the homepage of their respective

websites. The process was part of the initiatives to strengthen transparency, accountability, and outcome monitoring in organ transplantation nationwide. Asked for his views, a senior transplant surgeon in Chennai said crude mortality rates had very limited informational value for individual patients wanting to make a choice of hospitals. "Until risk-stratified mortality outcomes that have been duly scrutinised in an unbiased manner are available both from government and private hospitals, it will be near impossible to make informed choices," he said.

The data hospitals have been told to publish—number of patients alive after six months, one year, three years and five years—will be difficult to collate as there is no mechanism for such a follow-up, he said. "Deaths post-transplant happen due to a variety of reasons such as age, comorbidities and other risk factors. Even if post-survival data are shared by hospitals, it will be challenging to authenticate the veracity of the claims," he said.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



The Prime Ministers Museum and Library (PMML) will celebrate the 105th birth anniversary of the former Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao on Saturday with an exhibition showcasing a collection of rare photographs, official documents, speeches, correspondence and archival material tracing his journey in public life.

As a part of its regular activities, the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya (Prime Ministers' Museum) in New Delhi showcases the lives, vision and contributions of Prime Ministers since Independence and has started celebrating their birth anniversaries.

Rao was born on June 28, 1921, in Warangal district of present-day Telangana.

The exhibits will highlight his leadership during a critical phase in India's history and his role in introducing the landmark economic reforms of liberalisation, privatisation, and globalisation that transformed the nation's economic landscape.

The exhibition will explore Rao's multi-faceted

Audiovisual show

The exhibition, through photographs and audiovisual presentations, will provide visitors a deeper understanding of the life, vision, and legacy of Rao. It aims to celebrate the enduring legacy of the statesman often remembered as the architect of modern, globalised India, a senior official of the Culture Ministry said.

The exhibition will be open to visitors from June 27 at the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya.

EXPLAINER

A.M. Jigeeesh
NEW DELHI

The story so far: The Union Food and Public Distribution Department on Wednesday published a draft of the proposed amendments to the National Food Security Act (NFSA). The draft is uploaded on the department's website. The public can comment on the amendments till July 13.

The amendment

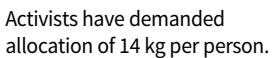
A new provision in Section 3 of the National Food Security Act, 2013, proposes that every person belonging to households covered under the Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) shall be entitled to 7 kg of foodgrains every month to a maximum of 35 kg per household. For AAY cardholders, this allocation will be free of any

charges. Earlier, it was 35 kg per AAY household, irrespective of the number of members in the household.

Reason

The reason the Union government has given in the notice, along with the draft amendment, is that the existing household-based entitlement under the AAY, though intended as a protective measure for the most vulnerable families, results in significant inequities depending upon the size of the household.

“Smaller households receive a higher per-capita entitlement, whereas larger households receive a lower per-capita entitlement, which may fall below the entitlement available to priority households,” the notice adds. The government maintains that the aim and purpose are to remove “intra-category inequities,



provide for more rational foodgrain allocation and better align entitlements with nutritional requirements.”

Criticism

Certain non-BJP-ruled States and activists of the Right to Food Campaign have voiced concerns over the amendment. Kerala Food Minister Anoop Jacob told presspersons that the State government would write to the Union government against the proposed amendment. He said the

Solution to previous puzzle

C	E	L	L	R	B	A	K	L	E	G
O	E	L	L	T	H	O	A			
R	U	M	B	L	I	M	P	E	R	I
U	O	O	S	B	A	T	O			
N	O	N	E	V	E	N	E	S	T	R
E	S	S	T	R	E	S	S			
U	N	D	E	R	B	R	E	A	T	H
M	E	T	I	B	E	G	L	O	T	
			H	A	N	D	I	N	G	L
A	T	E	G	T	A	W	R			
G	R	U	M	P	S	B	A	L	L	R
E	N	L	B	T	L	O	R	I		
O	D	D	B	A	L	L	S	L	O	O
L	R	C	A			U	S	E	U	
D	E	A	D	E	N	S				
U	R	P	S							

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	9	7	8	6	3	1	4	2
1	6	3	9	4	2	8	5	7
4	2	8	7	5	1	9	3	6
8	7	5	2	3	4	6	1	9
2	3	1	6	9	8	5	7	4
6	4	9	1	7	5	2	8	3
3	8	4	5	2	9	7	6	1
9	5	6	4	1	7	3	2	8
7	1	2	3	8	6	4	9	5

The power of a local deity is a subaltern reality when it comes to faith. Local legends hold a powerful sway over communities that are large in number but outside the elitist spectrum. Spiritual speakers acknowledge this frequently and in fact attribute the local deity, a Kali, as a legendary manifestation of Ambal, Thayar, Varahi, Parvati, etc., and of Shiva and Vishnu as Ayyanar, Karuppusamy, etc. To the faithful, they are simply their everyday protectors, said P. Swaminathan in a discourse.

The Vettudaiyal temple in Ariyakurichi village of Tamil Nadu's Sivaganga district boasts of one such legend. Udaiyal, a 12-year-old girl, herding cattle was martyred when confronted by British mercenaries. The local king, Muthu Vadagunatha Udaiyal, was an ardent devotee of Lord Shiva. He was ambushed by the same mercenaries, since he refused to bow to the British who were attempting to colonise the region and remained patriotic.

After the king's death, his wife Velu Nachiyar carried forward his political legacy. On one occasion when she was chased by the mercenaries, the legendary queen took shelter off a fork of a road and the pursuers sought to know her whereabouts from the young Udaiyal herding cattle there. Udaiyal refused to divulge any information and was martyred. Velu Nachiyar built a shrine for the girl eight years later. By then the girl, Vettudaiyal (*vettu + udaiyal* – a strike on the one who possesses everything) had become a legend, a protector of the masses.

The legend grew over the centuries and to this day, people continue to appeal to Her for grace, for resolution of their problems and for everyday protection.

INBRIEF



GMR Airports takes over operations of Nagpur airport

Airport developer GMR Airports Ltd. took over the operations of Nagpur's Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar International Airport on Friday. "The first phase will focus on expanding the passenger terminal to accommodate three million travellers annually, ensuring a seamless and efficient travel experience," chairman, GMR Airports, GBS Raju was quoted in a press statement. Future phases aim at raising the airport's capacity to serve up to 30 million passengers annually, backed by extensive airside infrastructure upgrades, including the construction of a new Air Traffic Control tower. The airport will feature a state-of-the-art cargo terminal with an annual handling capacity of 20,000 metric tonne. GMR Nagpur International Airport Ltd. (GNIAL) signed a 30-year concession agreement in November 2024 with MIHAN India Ltd. to operate, manage, develop and modernise the airport.

Middlemen offer Iranian oil to India refiners on U.S. waiver

Several middlemen have offered Indian refiners discounted Iranian oil as Tehran looks to expedite sales after Washington's temporary sanctions waiver, Indian refining sources said. On Monday, the United States waived sanctions on Iran for 60 days after the first talks under a nascent peace deal, opening a narrow window for renewed energy trade. The approaches to Indian refiners have come directly from National Iranian Oil Co (NIOC) and through intermediaries saying they have been allocated oil by the Iranian state producer, the sources said. "Apart from NIOC, several traders are contacting us for the sale of Iranian oil. But my priority is to give a chance to NIOC," said a refining source. The sources declined to be named. NIOC is telling Indian buyers Iranian crude would be \$3 to \$4 a barrel cheaper than similar regional grades. The traders are mainly from small and mid-sized trading firms based in Singapore and Dubai, the sources said, declining to name them. REUTERS

Businessline MSME meet on crisis resilience

BL Bureau
CHENNAI

Celebrating MSMEs, *The Hindu businessline* brings its 5th annual MSME Conclave to two cities. After kicking off in Bengaluru on June 25, it reaches Coimbatore on June 27 where it will focus on financing strategies to aid small firms navigate crisis and shift to clean mobility. It will discuss MSMEs' contribution to the Indian growth story. The theme for Coimbatore event is 'Resilient Routes: Financing MSMEs from Crisis to Clean Mobility'. Keynote speaker is Jairam Varadaraaj, MD, ELGI Equipments. Businessline Editor Raghuvir Srinivasan will address the audience.

The event will have two panel discussions and a fireside chat. There will be a special address on 'Kerala: Your next investment destination'. The first panel will discuss 'Financing in times of war' and have Karthikeyan Mounaguruswamy, immediate past President, CODISSIA; Rahul Jyothi Kumaran, Head-SME business, Sundaram Finance and Kumar Duraiswamy, CEO, Eastern Global Clothing and Joint Secretary, Tiruppur Exporters Association and session moderated by Lokeshwarri S. K., Data Editor, *The Hindu businessline*.

The second panel is on "The Clean Mobility Opportunity for MSMEs". The panellists include Dr. S. Chandrasekar, Corporate Director - Roots Group of Companies, Founder Trus-



tee & VP - Society for Smart E-mobility; Shreshth Mishra, Co-founder & Chief People Officer, Simple Energy and Sudeepth Puthumana, Head of Mobility, L&T Electronic Products and Systems with the session moderated by Ramesh M, Consulting Editor, *The Hindu businessline*.

The fireside chat with Ravichandran Purushothaman, Chairman-CII Southern Region and President, Danfoss India will be hosted by Richa Mishra, Resident Editor, *The Hindu businessline*. A special address on 'Kerala: Your next investment destination' will be given by Arun K. Vijayan, IAS, Director, Industries and MD, KSIDC.

The conclave is co-powered by Kerala State Industrial Development Corporation and the Central Bank of India. The Associate Partners are Bank of Baroda, Tally, SSVN Institutions, Indian Overseas Bank, Salzer, South Indian Bank, Turbo Engineering, Zorian Systems, Suguna Pumps & Motors, Malles Construction, eRoyce Motors India, and Ruh Continuum School. The Realty Partner is G Square and Lifestyle Partner is Lexus.



Govt. to simplify drug import rules for test, examination, analysis

Ministry already amended New Drugs and Clinical Trials Rules, 2019 in Jan. 2026 introducing similar notification system for local test licences

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

Union Health Ministry has proposed amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945 to simplify the procedure for securing permission for import of drugs for examination, test or analysis. The change introduces an acknowledgement-based system for import of all drugs in small quantities for analytical and non-clinical testing purposes.

Under the revised provisions, applicants intending to import such drugs will be required to submit a prior intimation form and may import the drug based on the acknowledgement generated upon submission of such intimation.

The procedure is applicable for import of drugs for analytical and non-clinical testing, except for certain drugs belonging to the categories of sex hormones, cytotoxic drugs, beta lactam drugs, biologics containing live microorganisms and narcotic and psychotropic substances, said a release issued by the Health Ministry.

The Ministry has already carried out amendments to the New Drugs and Clinical Trials Rules, 2019 in January introducing a similar notification system for domestic test licences. The present proposed amendment expands it to imports also.



Right prescription: The amendment is expected to significantly cut compliance burden on applicants. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

The amendment is expected to significantly cut compliance burden on applicants by eliminating licensing needs for importing small lots of drugs for testing or R&D purposes.

Deregulation role

"This will play a substantial role in deregulating the R&D sector in pharmaceuticals and enable start-ups and industries to quickly initiate testing or analysis. The online intimation system will offer a seamless and instant gateway for the stakeholders," said a senior health official. The draft has been placed in the public domain for stakeholder consultation.

Meanwhile, the Ministry also published a draft notification proposing amendments to Rule 31 of the Drugs Rules, 1945 with the goal of rationalising the residual shelf-life norm for imported drugs and proposed ease of doing business in the pharma sector.

The draft amendment proposes to revise the norm of a minimum residual shelf life of more than 60% for imported drugs to a minimum residual shelf life of 12 months at the time of import. However, in view of specialised nature and public health considerations, the existing norm of a minimum residual shelf life of more than 60% shall continue to apply to biological products and radio pharmaceuticals.

The proposed amendment seeks to aid more efficiency in the pharmaceutical supply chain while maintaining availability of quality medicines for patients. By ensuring imported drugs have a minimum remaining shelf life of 12 months upon entry into the country, the proposal provides sufficient time for distribution and consumption before expiry, thereby ensuring patients continue to receive medicines with adequate usable shelf life.

IMO pauses Gulf vessel evacuation as Iran attacks ship

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

The International Maritime Organization (IMO) Secretary-General Arsenio Dominguez said the agency has paused its involvement in the evacuation of vessels stranded in the Persian Gulf following an Iranian attack on a commercial ship transiting the Strait of Hormuz through the southern Oman route.

Mr. Dominguez said the vessel, Taiwan's container ship *Ever Lovely*, was not transiting under the IMO-facilitated plan.

The IMO Secretary General said he did not know whether the ship had been in touch with the U.S. Navy before the incident. No one was injured and the vessel resumed its voyage.

The attack followed a joint declaration by the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) States, including Oman, after a meeting attended by the United States, stating that there should be no "tolls, fees, or attempts to assert control over the strait."

Iran criticises move

Iran has criticised The International Maritime Organization plan, arguing it does not adequately recognise Tehran's role in managing traffic through the strategic waterway.

Mr. Dominguez, however, said the Foreign Ministers of Oman and Iran met on Monday (June 22, 2026), and the Organisation's plan was announced the following day based on those discussions.

According to a statement issued by Iran after

About 500 ships are in the area and evacuating them could take about five weeks, says IMO

the conclusion of that meeting, the "two countries had agreed to continue talks through a joint committee of their Foreign Ministries to reach an understanding on the future management of shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, the services to be provided and the associated costs, in accordance with international standards."

115 vessels transit Strait

Mr. Dominguez said some 115 vessels had transited the strait from the beginning of the week to the pause. Since the attack, four ships have used the northern route and 11 the southern route. He said shipowners should conduct their own risk assessments before transiting the strait now that IMO has paused its role.

'Assurances needed'

The IMO remains in contact with Iran via its embassy in London, where the organisation is headquartered, he said.

Mr. Dominguez said the IMO would resume its role once all stakeholder-nations provide 'guarantees' on safety of ships and seafarers.

About 500 ships are in the area and evacuating them could take about five weeks, he added, noting that both Oman and Iran exercise jurisdiction over the Strait of Hormuz.



Anil Ambani

SEBI rejects Anil Ambani's settlement plea for RInfra

Reuters
MUMBAI

India's financial markets regulator has rejected applications by industrialist Anil Ambani and his corporate group to settle allegations of misusing almost \$700 million of company funds, documents reviewed by *Reuters* show.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India last week rejected the requests over allegations that Ambani and Reliance Infrastructure were involved in improperly routing ₹6,526 crore (\$691 million) to entities related to controlling shareholder Ambani, the documents show.

Mr. Ambani, the younger brother of billionaire Mukesh Ambani, has faced growing scrutiny from regulators and enforcement agencies over the past 18 months. Several group executives have been arrested on fraud charges and some of Mr. Anil Ambani's properties frozen.

A spokesperson for the Anil Ambani group said: "The allegations are categorically denied. The matters are sub judice."

SEBI did not respond to a request for comment.

Govt. eases Quality Control Order rules

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Union government has eased the most stringent aspects of the Quality Control Orders (QCOs) it has passed for various sectors, allowing manufacturers to use an alternative mechanism to transition to the more stringent version over the course of five years.

From 2020, the government has been issuing QCOs in an attempt to improve the quality standards of Indian manufacturing and protect consumer interests. These standards, however, met with significant opposition from local manufacturers who said the compliance process was long and paperwork arduous.

The latest notification by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, called

the Transition Facilitation (Quality Control) Order, 2026, "introduces an alternative risk-based compliance mechanism to facilitate a smooth transition for industry while maintaining quality assurance and consumer protection," the Ministry said.

Basically, the notification allows selected local firms to procure supplies from manufacturers holding licences under the less rigorous Scheme II of Schedule II of the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) regulations, instead of the more rigorous Scheme I.

As per the notification, this relaxation would apply to the QCOs on toys, personal protective footwear, air conditioners, rubber footwear, electric water heaters, washing machines, hinges, furniture, and electrical safety equipment.

Zydus JV to set up \$20-mn Lanka unit

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Zydus Lifesciences and Sunshine Healthcare Lanka have formed a joint venture (JV) to build a \$20 million pharmaceutical manufacturing facility in Sri Lanka.

Foundation stone of the nearly four-acre facility of the JV, Zydus Sunshine Lifesciences, at the Board of Investment zone in Horana was laid on Friday.

Coming against the backdrop of Sri Lanka prioritising domestic pro-

duction in essential sectors, the plant will boost local output, contribute to cut in import dependence and improve access to high-quality medicines.

It would make pharmaceutical products for Sri Lanka's retail market.

The JV combines Zydus' global pharma making and technical know-how with Sunshine's strong local market presence and healthcare distribution capabilities and would support technology transfer, build local manufacturing capability and create jobs.

BHAKRA BEAS MANAGEMENT BOARD
(A Statutory Body under the Ministry of Power, Government of India)
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
BBMB invites online (**Bid No.: GEM/2026/B/7713362**) on the GeM Portal for the appointment of an IRDAI-Registered Composite Insurance Broker for providing Insurance Consultancy Services to BBMB for a period of two years from the date of award of work.
For detailed tender, please visit the GeM Portal or www.bbmb.gov.in.
290-PR-Bd. Sectt.-5 For your Better Tomorrow Save Energy Today

कार्यालय नगर निगम जोधपुर
नगर निगम भवन, पोलीटेक्नीकल कॉलेज परिसर के अन्दर, गौरव पथ, जोधपुर
फोन संख्या:- 0291-2651464, फैक्स:- 0291-2641464, ई-मेल:- ceonji@gmail.com
क्रमांक:- 5193 दिनांक:- 23.06.2026
E-Notice Inviting Bid
U.B. No. DLB2627GLOB08637
Bid For Municipal Corporation Jodhpur For Works (01) DateInvited
Form Interested Bidders Date 23.06.2026 Upto 14.07.2026 Other Particulars Of The Bid May Be Downloaded On The Procurement Portal <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>, Of The State.
राज.संवाद / सी / 26 / 5651 उपस्थित नगर निगम जोधपुर

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, संभाग-कोटा
क्रमांक : 776 दिनांक : 17.06.2026
निविदा सूचना संख्या-09/ 2026-27
NIB No- PWD2627A1224
राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से बारा जिले में बजट घोषणा 2025-26 के अन्तर्गत **ROB पुल का निर्माण कार्य दस साल की सरम्मत के लिए ई पी सी. चोड पर 1 कार्य** उपयुक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग राजस्थान में पंजीकृत संवेदकों एवं राज्य सरकार/ केन्द्र सरकार के अधिकृत संगठनों/ केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग/ डाक एवं दूर संचार विभाग/ रेलवे इत्यादि में पंजीकृत संवेदकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के एए श्रेणी के संवेदकों के समकक्ष हों, से निर्धारित प्रारंभ में ई-प्रोक्चरमेंट प्रक्रिया से ऑन लाईन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विवरण वेब साईट <http://dnpr.rajjasthan.gov.in> व <http://pwd.rajjasthan.gov.in> <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है। यु.बी. एन संख्या निम्नानुसार है।
इच्छुक संवेदकों को अपने डिजिटल हस्ताक्षर के माध्यम से वेबसाईट <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> पर रजिस्टर्ड होना आवश्यक है।
UBN No. PWD2627WLOB05240
अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता
सांनिधि सम्भाग कोटा
DIPRC/11028/26

OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER PWD ZONE-I JAIPUR
PWD Campus, Jacob Road, Infront of Jaipur Club, Jaipur (C) 0141-2223525
No.: ACE-I/Zone-I/NT No. 03/2026-27/D-547 Date: 18/06/2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
Budget Announcement 2026-27 widening and strengthening road work of Jhunjhunu District is invited from interested bidders from dated 22.06.2026 at 09:30 AM upto dated 13.07.2026 at 06:00 PM, other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state; and pwd.rajjasthan.gov.in in departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is **Rs. 3296.71 lacs.**
NIB No.

S.N.	District	Name of Work	UBN No.
1	Jhunjhunu	रामपुर से डाबड़ी घोर सिंह तक डामर सड़क चौड़ाईकरण एवं सुदृढ़ीकरण कार्य।	PWD2627 WLOB05341
2	Jhunjhunu	सुदृढ़ीकरण एवं चौड़ाईकरण कार्य डाडाफलेतपुर-नालपुर-गौर-रामवास तक सड़क	PWD2627 WLOB05342
3	Jhunjhunu	गाझुखेड़ा-साहसपुर-रामपुर सेनाना-पालोता-बुलना सड़क चौड़ाईकरण एवं सुदृढ़ीकरण कार्य।	PWD2627 WLOB05343
4	Jhunjhunu	सरगनाह-स्वामी सेही-तोला सेही-डालनियों की दाणी (चिडावा ए-एच-11 न्यू) तक सड़क चौड़ाईकरण एवं सुदृढ़ीकरण कार्य।	PWD2627 WLOB05344

(Anupam Gupta)
Additional Chief Engineer
PWD Zone-I Jaipur
DIPRC/11114/26

कृषि विश्वविद्यालय, जोधपुर
जोधपुर 342804, राजस्थान, भारत
ई-निविदा 05/2026-27
कृषि विश्वविद्यालय, जोधपुर द्वारा Rate Contract of Chemical, Glassware, Plasticware and Other Lab Consumables की आपूर्ति करने हेतु ऑनलाइन ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा संबंधी विस्तृत विवरण एवं जानकारी www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in एवं <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> पर उपलब्ध है।
UBN NO. : JAU2627GLRC00060
राज.संवाद / सी / 26 / 5699 निरवक्र (वि)

GOVERNMENT OF RAJASTHAN
OFFICE OF THE GENERAL MANAGER, RAJASTHAN BHAWAN
Plot No. 21-22, Sector 30A, Vashi, Navi Mumbai-400703
Tel. No. 022-27811790/27811194/27811195, Email:-rbvashi@rajasthan.gov.in
No.: RBV/2026-27/NIB/40 Date: 19.06.2026
Notice Inviting Bid-01
Bids for Providing following Services at Rajasthan Bhawan, Vashi are invited from interested Bidders. Other particulars of the Bid may be viewed on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> and <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state.

Sr. No	Bid Detail	Last date & Time for submitting of E-Bid	Portal	UBN No./E-Proc Bid ID No
1	Facility Operation Services	13-07-2026 Up to 05.00 PM	E-Proc	2026_GAD_569471_1
2	Security Services	04-07-2026 Up to 05.00 PM	SPPP	GAD2627SLRC00005
			SPPP	2026_GAD_569497_1
			SPPP	GAD2627SLRC00006

General Manager
Rajasthan Bhawan, Vashi, Navi Mumbai
DIPRC/11181/2026

RajCOMP Info Services Limited (RISL)
C-Block, 1st Floor, Yojana Bhawan, Tilak Marg, C-Scheme, Jaipur
RISL invites e-bids from the eligible bidders for the following:

NIB No./ Date/ Unique bid no.	Particulars	Estimated Cost/EMD	Start of sale / Last date
RIS2627A0036/ 22.06.2026	RFP - Selection for System Integrator for Wildlife Surveillance & Anti - Poaching System (National Chambal Sanctuary) in Rajasthan Including Operation & Maintenance for a Period of five Years based on Open Competitive Bidding through e-Procurement/ e-Tender.	Rs. 40 Cr.	22.06.2026/ 22.07.2026

Details can be seen on the websites <http://risl.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://doitc.rajjasthan.gov.in>. Bids are to be submitted through <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>
Raj.Samwad/C/26/5690 Technical Director

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur-302004
S. No. : JDA/EE & TA to Dir. Engg.-I/2026-27/D- Dated : 25.06.2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No.: EE & TA to Dir. Engg.-I/13/2026-27
Bids are invited from interested bidders for following works :-

S. No.	UBN No.	Cost of Work (Lacs)	Nature of Work	Last Date
1	JDA2627WSOB00162	453.32	Electric Work	03.07.2026

Other particulars of the respective bid may be visited on Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajjasthan.gov.in.
Executive Engineer & TA to Dir.Engg-I
Raj.Samwad/C/26/5760

BEIRUT

Hezbollah chief says Israel must ‘unconditionally’ leave Lebanon



REUTERS

Hezbollah leader Naim Qassem on Friday said Israel has “no option” but to withdraw from Lebanese areas it occupies, adding that the Iran-U.S. deal that reduced fighting with Israel was an American-Israeli defeat. “Israel has no option but to withdraw completely from every inch of our Lebanese land,” he said. AFP

WASHINGTON

Lebanon, Israel, U.S. sign trilateral framework accord in Washington



REUTERS

Lebanon, Israel and the U.S. on Friday signed a trilateral framework agreement aimed at paving the way for a peace deal between the two long-time West Asia adversaries. Lebanon’s ambassador to Washington, Nada Hamadeh Moawad, said the accord “is a first step on the road to restoring Lebanese sovereignty”, AFP

GREENBELT

Ex-Trump adviser Bolton pleads guilty in classified documents case



AP

John Bolton, a former national security adviser for U.S. President Donald Trump who has since become one of his fiercest critics, pleaded guilty in federal court on Friday to mishandling classified information and faces up to five years in prison. “I’m sorry for it,” Mr. Bolton said during the hearing. REUTERS

BRUSSELS

EU proposes to refuse military-age Ukrainian men refugee protection



REUTERS

The EU on Friday proposed stopping granting Ukrainian men of fighting age refugee protection to settle in the bloc, while extending the right beyond 2027 for others from the country. Brussels said the change follows a request from Kyiv, whose army has struggled with manpower shortages as Russia’s war grinds into a fifth year. AFP

‘China’s Bangladesh ties doesn’t target third party’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

China’s relation with Bangladesh does not “target” a third party, China’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs said on Friday. The remark came soon after China expressed support for Bangladesh’s Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project and said it will expedite a feasibility study.

The discussion on the Teesta river took place during Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman’s first official visit to China. Mr. Rahman was hosted by Premier Li Qiang and had a meeting with President Xi Jinping during June 25-26.

Mr. Xi, during his meeting with Mr. Rahman, assured that China will remain a “trusted friend” of Bangladesh and help in im-



Xi Jinping

plementing the development plans of the BNP government. Mr. Rahman on his part conveyed Bangladesh’s commitment to “one China policy”.

The two sides expressed support for “high quality cooperation” as part of the Belt and Road Initiative and work jointly towards modernisation. China supported greater role for Bangladesh in multilateral organisations like the UN, and supported “Bangla-

desh to participate in the BRICS” and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation.

Mr. Rahman appreciated zero-tariff treatment for 100% tariff lines, and said Dhaka will help facilitate greater Chinese investments. The two sides agreed to advance modernisation of the Mongla port and develop a Chinese Economic and Industrial Zone (CEIZ) in Chittagong.

China also appreciated Bangladesh for hosting the Rohingya refugees of the Rakhine state who were evicted by Myanmar in 2017. China expressed support for “friendly consultation” with Myanmar and Bangladesh to settle the refugee crisis. The joint statement on the matter, however, did not use the term “Rohingya” and used “forcibly displaced people from Rakhine state of Myanmar”.

Iran reasserts its right to control shipping in Hormuz after vessel hit

Tehran says U.S. military presence in the Gulf is the source of regional insecurity and division, and that the Hormuz Strait should be governed by Iran and Oman; state media says three tankers attempting ‘unauthorised passage’ were turned back

Reuters
DUBAI/LONDON

Tehran reasserted its right on Friday to control shipping in the Strait of Hormuz and warned Gulf states against siding with the U.S., a day after an attack on a ship near Oman highlighted the fragility of a preliminary deal to end the Iran war.

Iran was responding to what it called an “interventionist, irresponsible and provocative” joint statement by the U.S. and six Gulf states that rejected Iran’s insistence that it could charge tolls on vessels transiting the strait.

“Safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz cannot be guaranteed under



Dangerous passage: Vessels at the Strait of Hormuz, as seen from Musandam, Oman, on Friday. REUTERS

ambiguous arrangements, parallel routes or decision-making that does not take Iran’s role as a coastal state into account,” Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gha-

ribabadi said on X.

Underlining the risks facing shipping, Iranian state TV later reported that three foreign tankers attempting what it called an “unauthorised passage” of

the strait were turned back after a warning from the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps.

Rubio in the Gulf

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio – wrapping up a tour of the Gulf to reassure nervous regional allies about the interim pact – told presspersons on Thursday that if Iran threatened or blocked ships in the strait, “we’re going to have a problem”.

In their joint statement, Mr. Rubio and the GCC called for “free, unconditional, and unrestricted navigation” in the strait without tolls or “attempts to assert control”, and said a lasting peace must address

Iran’s ballistic missiles, drones and support for proxy groups. Iran’s Foreign Ministry responded on Friday by saying the U.S. military presence in the Gulf was the source of regional insecurity and division, and that the strait should be governed by Iran and Oman in line with the terms of the interim deal.

Ali Akbar Velayati, top adviser to Iran’s Supreme Leader, issued a warning to Washington’s Gulf allies.

“The stability of the Persian Gulf Arab states is indebted to Iran’s century-long management of the Strait of Hormuz... their strategic survival is at the mercy of Tehran’s tolerance,” Mr. Velayati said.

OpenAI defers public rollout of GPT 5.6 as U.S. seeks early access

Reuters
NEW YORK

OpenAI said on Friday it was delaying a full public launch of GPT-5.6 at the U.S. government’s request, limiting the AI model’s initial access to a small group of vetted partners. The decision underscores growing concern in Washington over national security risks posed by powerful AI systems.

OpenAI said in a blog post that the limited release was a temporary step as it works with Washington on a broader framework for future launches.

President Donald Trump signed an executive

order earlier this month establishing a voluntary framework for AI developers to offer “covered frontier models” to the U.S. government for up to 30 days before releasing them to trusted partners.

“We are taking this short-term step as we believe it is the strongest path to broader availability in the coming weeks, while we work with the Administration to develop the cyber Executive Order framework,” OpenAI said.

Earlier this month, the U.S. government ordered Anthropic to suspend access to its frontier AI models for foreign nationals, citing security concerns.

Venezuela twin earthquakes toll rises to 920, says official

Agence France-Presse
LA GUAIRA

The death toll from two twin earthquakes that devastated Venezuela earlier this week rose to 920 on Friday, National Assembly President Jorge Rodriguez said.

In a televised address, Mr. Rodriguez updated the death toll that had previously been at 589, as rescuers boosted by international teams raced to find survivors beneath collapsed buildings.

Rescuers used heavy machinery but also just bare hands in a race to pluck out people caught under rubble in the earthquake zone west of the capital Caracas.



Jorge Rodriguez

At one of the flattened buildings, AFP saw workers using sledgehammers to break the debris and calling for “absolute silence” to detect cries from survivors. However, the abrupt increase in the official toll was only expected to keep rising.

“Regrettably, we now have 589 people who

died,” Interim President Delcy Rodriguez told a televised meeting earlier in the day. The previous official toll had been 235, while Health Minister Carlos Alvarado said late Thursday that another 4,300 people were listed as injured.

Help has begun to arrive, with Salvadoran, Swiss and Mexican rescue teams already on the ground, as well as a senior U.S. military official landing in Caracas to oversee Washington’s relief efforts.

Nations around the world have pledged to send rescuers, money and aid, with the United States saying it was deploying two warships, transport planes and helicopters, and mobilising \$150 million in aid.

Ebola deaths top 300 in DR Congo

KINSHASA

The Ebola epidemic has claimed more than 300 lives in the Democratic Republic of Congo, a little over one month after it was declared, health authorities said on Friday. AFP

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Notice No.: APMF-2559296

Sd/- MANAGING DIRECTOR

Crimea declares ‘emergency’ amid Ukrainian strikes as Russia downs 660 drones overnight

Agence France-Presse
MOSCOW

Authorities in Russian-annexed Crimea on Friday declared an “emergency situation” in a bid to ease the fallout from increasing Ukrainian aerial attacks on the peninsula.

The announcement comes amid fuel shortages and power cuts triggered by the Ukrainian attacks on logistics chains and oil facilities across Crimea, the rest of Russian-held Ukraine and southern Russia.

“A decision has been made... to sign decrees declaring a regional-level emergency situation in the Republic of Crimea and the city of Sevastopol,” the Moscow-installed governor

Sergey Aksyonov said in a post on Telegram.

The emergency situation would allow for a “rapid resolution of tasks related to ensuring the stable operation of all sectors”, Mr. Aksyonov said.

Kyiv has stepped up its air attacks that it calls fair retribution for Russia’s near-daily barrages on Ukrainian civilians and energy infrastructure since Moscow launched its offensive in February 2022.

Barrage of drones

Russian air defences shot down 660 Ukrainian drones overnight, including over the capital Moscow and the annexed Crimea, its Defence Ministry said on Friday, one of the



A Ukrainian serviceman of the Khartia brigade controls a drone in the command centre in the Kharkiv region in Ukraine on Friday. AP

highest figures since the start of the conflict.

Drones were destroyed over more than a dozen regions, including the Russian capital and the annexed Crimean Peninsula, the Black Sea, and the Sea of Azov, the Ministry said

on Russia’s Max platform.

Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin, said at least 47 drones heading toward the capital were intercepted.

“Emergency services specialists are working where the debris fell,” Sobyanin said on Telegram,

without reporting any casualties or damage.

Ukraine mostly targets Russian oil processing and export facilities in a bid to deprive the Kremlin of a source of revenue crucial for financing Moscow’s war effort.

Last week, Kyiv’s attack caused a major fire at a refinery in the southeast of Moscow, shrouding the suburbs in plumes of thick black smoke.

Mr. Aksyonov had a day earlier acknowledged that Crimea “is going through a challenging time” and that “the fuel situation is the most difficult”.

He also conceded that the Russian army were unable to fully protect the peninsula.

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M CH-CH

Netherlands tops Group F with a facile victory over Tunisia



Germany committed 'tactical blunders', says Nagelsmann



Canada set to become first WC host to play away from home



Ongoing tournament becomes most-attended edition in history



Draw does the job for both Japan and Sweden



Ecuador squeezes into last 32 with upset win over Germany

Australia sails and Paraguay waits

Argentina likely to shuffle its pack for final group game

Stat attack

Compiled by **ANIRUDH VELAM**

Q: Qualified | E: Eliminated | The top two from each group and the eight best third-placed sides will advance to the round of 32

Celebration time: Australia finished second in Group D. REUTERS

There could be changes

tinue in goal.

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INBRIEF



Skipper de Silva's century rescues Sri Lanka

Dhananjaya de Silva's assured 13th Test hundred anchored a determined Sri Lankan batting effort with the visitors dismissed for 308 just before the close of the first day of the first Test of the two-match series against the West Indies at the Sir Vivian Richards Stadium on Thursday. De Silva found support in Dinesh Chandimal, the former captain contributing a 54.

The scores: Sri Lanka 308 in 71.5 overs (Chandimal 54, de Silva 120, Dinusha 43) vs West Indies 0/0 in 1 over.

Toss: West Indies.

Jurel's unbeaten ton takes India-A past 400-run mark

India-A struck twice after skipper Dhruv Jurel's unbeaten 141 (215b, 13x4, 1x6) propelled the visiting team to 452 for six declared in the opening innings of the first unofficial Test against Sri Lanka-A in Galle on Friday. Anshul Kamboj and Yash Thakur bagged a wicket each before SL-A reached 113 for two when the stumps were drawn on day two. Nuwanidu Fernando showed positive intent as he cracked seven fours to score an unbeaten 65, while Ashen Bandara (18 n.o.) was accompanying him at close of play.

The scores: India-A 452/6 decl. in 111.4 overs (Sai Sudharsan 132, Jurel 141 n.o., Rasheed 63, Gunasekara 3/84) vs Sri Lanka-A 113/2 in 31 overs (Fernando 65 n.o.).

LIVE TELECAST

FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 8.30 a.m. 2.30 & 5 a.m. (Sunday)

England vs New Zealand: Third Test, Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.

Women's T20 WC: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 3, 7 & 11 p.m.

Formula One: Austrian GP (Qualifying), F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 7.30 p.m.

WI vs SL: First Test, Day 3, FanCode, 7.30 p.m.

After exorcising Slam ghosts in Paris, Zverev arrives at Wimbledon a confident man

The 29-year-old has warmed up well by reaching the semifinals in Halle, but grass is not his strength; the German has an uninspiring 16-9 win-loss record at the All England Club

TENNIS

N. Sudarshan

One of the keys to success is to be at the right place at the right time. Alexander Zverev certainly was when he won his maiden Major at Roland-Garros earlier this month.

Carlos Alcaraz was absent. Jannik Sinner and Novak Djokovic bowed out early. And the German himself was playing some fine tennis on what was – and is – his most productive surface.

The title was his for the taking, and he did not disappoint, fighting off a spirited Flavio Cobolli over five sets in the summit clash.

After three losses in Grand Slam finals, the success in Paris would have brought as much relief as joy.

“It’s both,” Zverev told *The Hindu* from Halle, Germany. “I was very joyful. But overall, it will not bring many changes. I will continue to practise the same way and play the same way. I love playing tennis and that won’t change.”

Zverev admitted to having doubts that he would never win a Slam.

In fact, he was in a winning position in two of the three title matches – against Dominic Thiem at



The challenge ahead: Zverev feels he is playing good tennis now and wants to show it on the grass court. AP

the 2020 US Open and versus Alcaraz at the 2024 French Open – but blew both.

“Of course, you have those thoughts. It’s normal when you lose three Slam finals. And when you are in your fourth, you have a lot of ghosts in your mind. But in the end, I did it.”

The 29-year-old’s focus will now shift to Wimbledon, where he is the se-

cond seed like at the French Open.

He has warmed up well by reaching the semifinals in Halle, but grass is not his strength.

At the All England Club, he has an uninspiring 16-9 win-loss record and has never progressed beyond the fourth round.

Germany has a great history of grass-court tennis, having produced cham-

pions such as Steffi Graf, Boris Becker, Michael Stich and Angelique Kerber. Can Zverev aim to join them?

“It’s a difficult surface for me and that will never change,” he said.

“But I am happy to accept the challenge, and try and play my best tennis. I feel that I am playing good tennis right now. I just have to show it on a grass court”.



Long wait: Serena last played a singles match nearly four years ago. AP

Serena to face Joint on Wimbledon return

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Serena Williams was on Friday drawn to play Australia’s Maya Joint in the Wimbledon first round as the American legend returns to singles action after four years.

Serena retired in 2022 but the 23-time Grand Slam singles champion made a sensational comeback by playing in the Queen’s Club and Berlin Open doubles earlier in June.

The 44-year-old was given a wild card entry in the Wimbledon singles – a tournament she has won seven times.

If Serena beats World No. 53 Joint, a 20-year-old who has won just one of her past 14 matches, the American could face 29th seed and rising star Alexandra Eala of the Philippines in the second round.

A victory in the second round would raise the possibility of a potential blockbuster third round tie against reigning champion Iga Swiatek, who starts her title defence against American Taylor Townsend.

Serena, who has been practising at Wimbledon for the past week, last

played a singles match nearly four years ago at the US Open in what had appeared to be her farewell to the sport.

She has not played at Wimbledon since losing to Harmony Tan in the first round in 2022.

Her last Grand Slam match was the US Open third round defeat against Ajla Tomljanovic that seemed to have brought the curtain down on her astonishing career.

Serena is also playing in the doubles at Wimbledon with her sister Venus. The pair has won the All England Club doubles six times together.

Sinner vs. Kecmanovic
In the men’s singles draw on Friday, defending champion Jannik Sinner was pitted against Serbia’s Miomir Kecmanovic.

The World No. 1 has not played since suffering a shock defeat against Juan Manuel Cerundolo in the French Open second round in May.

Carlos Alcaraz is absent as he continues to recover from a wrist injury. Novak Djokovic starts his latest bid for a record 25th Grand Slam title against China’s Wu Yibing.

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LAST 2 DAYS



Antonelli hopes to bounce back after bump in the road

The Italian teen feels the Red Bull Ring in Austria will suit his Mercedes car better than the track in Barcelona; Russell warns his teammate that veteran Hamilton is back to his best

FORMULA ONE

Agence France-Presse
SPIELBERG

Formula One leader Kimi Antonelli said that a Mercedes upgrade would help him bounce back from his first defeat of the season while teammate George Russell warned that Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton was back to his "beautiful best".

Russell was the favourite for the drivers' title until his teenage partner Antonelli went on a record run of five consecutive wins, a streak that Hamilton ended in Barcelona two weeks ago. It was Hamilton's first victory for the 'scarlet Scuderia' after two consecutive second-place finishes. The 41-year-old climbed to second in the title race and is 41 points behind Antonelli.

But the Italian is keen to get back on track at the Austrian GP, an event that was declared a "heat hazard" by the FIA with temperatures set to hit 38 degrees Celsius or higher across the race weekend. Sunday's race will be followed by the British, Belgian and Hungarian



Healthy cushion: Antonelli holds a 41-point lead over second-placed Hamilton, AFP

Grands Prix before the four-week summer break. "I think that these are tracks where our car should adapt well," Antonelli said. "The Red Bull Ring should be more favourable than Barcelona was for us, even though we are expecting very high temperatures. It is a very demanding track for the car, especially since the alti-

tude reduces the amount of available oxygen. Having a fresh power unit is definitely good news," added the 19-year-old. His teammate Russell was full of praise for Hamilton. "Kimi is still very much the driver out in front and he is performing incredibly and consistently. But Ferrari feels like it is coming and Hamilton is at the forefront. It was great

to see Hamilton back doing what he does best," Russell said of Hamilton's record-increasing 106th career win. "You do not forget how to drive overnight. But you need yourself, your team, the set-up, the understanding of the tyres – you need everything to click and when it does, you fly. That was the case with Hamilton, it was beautiful."

Iron Mirage may score an encore in feature event

BENGALURU: Iron Mirage, who is in fine nick, may score an encore in the S.M. Cama Music and Production Pvt Ltd Juvenile Sprinters' Million (1,200m), the feature event of the races to be held here on Saturday (June 27). False rails (width about 5m from 1,600m to the winning post) will be in position.

1. SMART CHIEFTAN PLATE (1,400m), maiden 3-y-o only, (Terms), 2:00 p.m.: 1. Rampage (1) Yash 56, 2. Shining Path (4) Akshay K 56, 3. Taaqath (7) S. Saqlain 56, 4. Xanthos (5) Darshan 56, 5. Ashwa New York (2) Suraj 54.5, 6. Bellucci (6) Arvind K 54.5 and 7. Sindoor (3) Antony 54.5. **1. RAMPAGE, 2. ASHWA NEW YORK**

2. POONAWALLA STUD PLATE (Div. II), 1,200m, rated 40 to 65, 5-y-o & over, 2:30: 1. La Mcqueen (7) Aleemuddin 60, 2. Battle Lass (9) B. Nayak 56, 3. Defence Counsel (6) G. Vivek 56, 4. N

R 1 Victory (2) Jagadeesh 55.5, 5. Win Win (4) Hindu S 55.5, 6. Bestidentification (3) A. Asbar 55, 7. Aherne (5) Antony 54.5, 8. Basilica (1) Akshay K 52.5 and 9. Lauterbrunnen (8) Kiran Rai 52. **1. BESTIDENTIFICATION, 2. DEFENCE COUNSEL, 3. BASILICA**

3. ASTRONOMIC PLATE (2,000m), rated 40 to 65, 3:00: 1. Magnus (6) Neeraj 60, 2. Winfield (4) Antony 58, 3. Badshaah (7) Abdul Fazal 57.5, 4. Maana (1) Akshay K 55.5, 5. Youremanorborne (5) Sandesh 55.5, 6. Multi Success (2) Vishal Bunde 54.5, 7. Unforgettable Star (8) Yash 52.5 and 8. Storm Shadow (3) G. Vivek 51.5. **1. YOUREMANORBORNE, 2. MAANA, 3. UNFORGETTABLE STAR**

4. MANAGING COMMITTEE GOLD CUP (1,600m), rated 80 & above, 3:30: 1. Victor Hugo (5) A. Hangal 62, 2. Touch Of Grey (6) Saurav Rawat 57, 3. Xanthe (2)

Hindu S 55, 4. Emphatic (-) (-) 54.5, 5. Queen Of Kings (4) M. Prabhakaran 53.5, 6. Superstar (1) Yash 53 and 7. Promiseofthefuture (3) Neeraj 50. **1. XANTHE, 2. PROMISEOFTHEFUTURE**

5. S.M. CAMA MUSIC AND PRODUCTION PVT LTD JUVENILE SPRINTERS' MILLION (1,200m), 3-y-o only, (Terms), 4:00: 1. Burvestnik (1) Sandesh 57, 2. Iron Mirage (5) Akshay K 57, 3. A Great Buzz (4) Pavan 55.5, 4. Shrishti (3) Yash 55.5 and 5. Veera's Princess (2) S. Shareef 55.5. **1. IRON MIRAGE, 2. A GREAT BUZZ**

6. MALAKPET PLATE (1,300m), rated 20 to 45, 4:30: 1. Darrington (11) Pavan 60.5, 2. Coolie (5) B. Nayak 60, 3. Shining Ways (7) Suraj 59, 4. Lasya (3) Vishal Bunde 58, 5. Femme Fatale (6) Abdul Fazal 57.5, 6. Rocking Star (4) R. Pradeep 57, 7. Makoto (10) Vishal S 56, 8. Star Honour (9) Md.

Talib 55.5, 9. Annabelle (1) Antony 53, 10. Big B (8) Kiran Rai 52.5 and 11. Power Of The Sea (2) S. Shareef 52.5. **1. SHINING WAYS, 2. DARRINGTON, 3. ROCKING STAR**

7. POONAWALLA STUD PLATE (Div. I), 1,200m, rated 40 to 65, 5-y-o & over, 5:00: 1. Senor Cherie (1) Akshay K 62.5, 2. True Punch (9) Bhawani S 62, 3. Aquatic (8) S. Sachin 61.5, 4. Bezawada Sultan (2) Arul 61, 5. Royal Deccan (5) Antony 61, 6. Densetsu (7) Hindu S 57, 7. Kabali (6) R. Pradeep 55, 8. Stravinsky (4) Kiran Rai 55 and 9. Felisa (3) Arvind K 54.5. **1. SENOR CHERIE, 2. AQUATIC, 3. ROYAL DECCAN**

Day's best: IRON MIRAGE Double: BESTIDENTIFICATION -SHINING WAY Jkt: 3, 4, 5, 6 and 7; Mini Jkt: 4, 5, 6 and 7; Tr (i): 2, 3 and 4; (ii): 5, 6 and 7.

Serena's daughters witness mum gear up for Wimbledon comeback

TENNIS

Associated Press
LONDON

Serena Williams keeps on commenting half-jokingly about how "it's summer" and "the kids aren't in school" as the reasoning for her tennis comeback at age 44.

Turns out family might really be the biggest factor behind Serena's decision to return to the pro game after nearly four years away.

Her two daughters, eight-year-old Olympia and Adira, who is almost three, have been with her every step of the way as she played two doubles warm-up matches before accepting wild card invitations to both the singles and doubles (with older sister Venus) competitions at Wimbledon, which starts on Monday.

"Just finished a mean game of duck duck goose," Serena said on X shortly after her singles wild card was announced last weekend.

A big hint about Serena's return came when she posted a video of a training session last month with Adira on court helping with a resistance band.

"Rumour has it...I got a new trainer," Serena said in her Instagram caption. Christopher Eubanks, a



No dearth of support: Olympia, Adira and their dad Alexis Ohanian watch Serena and her doubles partner Mboko in action at the Queen's Club Championships. REUTERS

recently retired pro turned Tennis Channel commentator, saw up close how Serena interacted with her family at her first tournament back at Queen's Club, where he performed an on-court interview with the American great and doubles partner Victoria Mboko.

"There's no changes to her legacy that will come as a result of this return. I don't see anyone changing their mind about where Serena stands all-time," Eubanks said on Thursday of the 23-time Grand Slam singles champion.

"This is about more than just records. At this point, it's more about fami-

ly," said Eubanks. When Serena last played in singles at the 2022 US Open, Olympia had just turned five and Adira wasn't even born yet. "They will forever know (Serena) as, Oh, you know, mommy is the GOAT of tennis," Eubanks said, using the acronym for "greatest of all time."

"But then if they have memories of being able to actually watch her go through that training, to me, that feels like what this is about more than anything else," Eubanks added.

The biggest challenge for Serena in singles will likely be her fitness and movement, which on grass

is more nuanced than on other surfaces.

"The hardest part for me I always felt was the decelerating and the stopping because you have to take extra steps in order to come to a stop," said Eubanks, who reached the Wimbledon quarterfinals in 2023 and a career-high ranking of No. 29 that year.

Serena might come forward to the net more and attempt to end points more quickly than she used to – kind of how Novak Djokovic has used his volleying skills more in recent years.

"That would be," Eubanks said, "what I would expect to see."

TNCA INTER-DISTRICT U-19



Ranipet bags u-19 title with first innings lead Dindigul: M. Naveen's four for 54 and R. Rakesh's four for 51 helped Ranipet secure a 126-run first-innings lead over Tiruvallur in the final and clinch the TNCA inter-district u-19 tournament title at the NPR College ground on Friday.

The scores: Ranipet 273/9 in 90 overs & 44/1 in 9 overs drew with Tiruvallur 147 in 62.2 overs (M. Mohith Singh 70 n.o., M. Naveen 4/54, R. Rakesh 4/51).

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CMVK

M CH-CH

Upstaged, but not unseated – yet: George Russell’s succession struggle



GETTY IMAGES

The British driver has long been viewed as a potential F1 champion – and in a title-contending Mercedes, he thought his moment had arrived. But over the first seven races, he has been outshone by a challenger to his status as team leader: teen sensation Andrea Kimi Antonelli

S. Dipak Ragav

Since time immemorial, one of the key conflicts humanity has faced is the battle for succession. It can play out within kingdoms, corporate boardrooms and families. Sport is no exception to this phenomenon.

Generational showdowns

Across various sports, generational showdowns have produced countless iconic moments, which have emerged from interesting narrative arcs. Sometimes the presumptive successor takes over; sometimes a disruptor challenges the natural line of succession.

In the world of Formula One, Mercedes driver George Russell is currently involved in one such fight.

The British driver, who made his F1 debut in 2019, was marked out for great things at a young age. He won nearly every major category leading up to F1, with titles in F4, GP3 and F2.

His big moment came when he subbed for Lewis Hamilton in Bahrain in 2020 and was immediately faster than the other Mercedes driver, Valtteri Bottas. In 2022, Russell got his dream gig when he was selected to partner seven-time champion Hamilton at the Silver Arrows.

However, Mercedes, which had won the con-

Russell can take a lesson from Norris’ title-winning run last year, in which the latter was behind McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri until late in the season before turning the tables

structors’ title from 2014 to 2021, was dislodged from its perch in the sport’s ground-effect era (2022 to 2025) by Red Bull and then McLaren.

It meant Russell never had a chance to fight for the title and had to settle for the odd win on days when the Mercedes found its sweet spot in certain conditions and on specific track layouts.

But in the first three years, the 28-year-old did have the opportunity to go toe-to-toe with the sport’s most successful driver in Hamilton. It was here that Russell proved his worth as a potential champion, getting the better of his illustrious teammate in two out of their three seasons together. In 2024, Russell out-qualified Hamilton 19-5, underlining his searing pace.

After Hamilton joined Ferrari in 2025, Russell became the natural team leader. So when Mercedes hit the ground running this season under F1’s new rules, which introduced a novel engine concept with increased electrification, the expectation was that Russell would lead the team’s title charge.

And it appeared everything was falling into place for Russell after the first race in Melbourne, which he dominated from pole. However, since then, things haven’t gone to plan for the Briton, who has seen a challenge emerge from the other side of his garage.

Andrea Kimi Antonelli, who joined Mercedes last year, is viewed as a generational talent by team boss Toto Wolff, who backed the Italian to step into Hamilton’s shoes at 18. In his rookie season, though, Antonelli had a baptism of fire in a tricky car and was comprehensively beaten.

Russell would have fancied his chances in a championship-winning car this season even as the teenager – highly rated as he may be – found his footing in the big league.

Unfortunately for Russell, he is staring at a sit-

Deep inside, Russell will have the unsettling feeling of knowing that the thing he has worked for all his life, which seemed near, is slipping away from him at a critical juncture

uation he would seldom have imagined after the Australian GP.

The early part of 2026 shows how much luck can influence matters, and how things can spiral out of control.

Russell is yet to step onto the top step of the podium after Melbourne, while his teammate went on a five-race winning streak. The result: Russell is now 50 points behind Antonelli and third in the standings behind even Hamilton, who won his first race for Ferrari in Barcelona.

Slippery slope

Things started going downhill for Russell in the second race in China where a technical issue compromised his qualifying. Though he recovered to qualify second, he got mugged at the start by the Ferraris and had to fight his way back to second, allowing his colleague to take his maiden win. In Japan, a Safety Car intervention led to him being jumped by Antonelli.

It was the start of a difficult run, and over the next three rounds, Russell was comprehensively

beaten in two – Miami and Monaco – while in between, in Montreal, he suffered a costly retirement due to engine trouble.

Although Russell trimmed his deficit in Barcelona, finishing second while Antonelli retired, the way the weekend unfolded was a source of more concern. Russell had the measure of the 19-year-old for most of the weekend, but the Bologna native slowly kept improving. By the time Antonelli retired, he had surpassed Russell on track with a fine overtaking manoeuvre.

Russell’s strength has been his one-lap pace, but so far this year, he trails 3-4 in qualifying. While a large part of the points difference is down to factors beyond his control, the recent dip in performance is the more alarming sign.

One reason the driver has identified is that his driving style is affecting the tyres.

“The difference is how we’re driving has such an impact on the tyres. He’s just getting the tyres in a nicer window than me, a nicer balance over the course of a lap, and the pace is just coming easier for him. I’m not sure why that is. I’ve been driving in this manner my whole career, and now, for whatever reason, it’s not working with this car,” Russell remarked recently.

He seemed perplexed that what worked in the first few rounds is now hurting him. At the same time, it could also be that he is over-driving to reassert his authority.

Known for his sophisticated and quintessentially British vocabulary, he has even resorted to mind games, tempering expectations by saying the title race is his rival’s to lose despite nearly two-thirds of the season remaining.

But deep inside, Russell will have the unsettling feeling of knowing that the thing he has worked for all his life, which seemed near, is slipping away from him at a critical juncture.

While he has experience on his side, it is no secret that over the last two years, his drive has been under threat from Max Verstappen, whom Wolff has courted for over a decade. In fact, the idea of promoting Kimi very early was driven by the fact that the Mercedes boss did not want to repeat the mistake he made by failing to sign Verstappen straightaway in 2014.

Considering his compatriot Lando Norris, whom he beat for the F2 title in 2018, is already a world champion, Russell would want to make full use of this opportunity. In F1, you never know when the next chance will present itself.

Crucial period

The races leading into August’s summer break could well prove crucial. Russell can ill-afford any more slips with Ferrari and McLaren mixing it up at the front with Mercedes.

In fact, he can take a lesson from Norris’ title-winning run last year, in which the latter was behind McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri until late in the season before turning the tables in the final stretch. Fortunately for Russell, he has more time to get things back on track. And it is often how one responds under pressure that determines how good one is. Can Russell show that he is a worthy successor to the line of Mercedes champions?



STACKING UP



ATP Men’s Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	24	13,450	18
2	Carlos Alcaraz	23	9,460	17
3	Alexander Zverev	29	7,190	20
4	Felix Auger-Aliassime	25	4,440	24
5	Ben Shelton	23	4,160	23
6	Alex de Minaur	27	4,110	24
7	Taylor Fritz	28	3,915	23
8	Novak Djokovic	39	3,760	16
9	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,580	24
10	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,460	27
11	Alexander Bublik	29	2,620	26
12	Casper Ruud	27	2,425	22
13	Andrey Rublev	28	2,420	23
14	Jiri Lehecka	24	2,360	21
15	Lorenzo Musetti	24	2,325	22

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 285 ▼ 2 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 382 ▼ 4 spots



F1 Drivers’ standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	156	5
2	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	115	1
3	G. Russell	Mercedes	106	1
4	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	75	0
5	L. Norris	McLaren	73	0
6	O. Piastri	McLaren	68	0
7	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	55	0
8	P. Gasly	Alpine	41	0
9	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	34	0
10	L. Lawson	RB	28	0
11	O. Bearman	Haas	18	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	16	0
13	A. Lindblad	RB	13	0
14	C. Sainz	Williams	6	0
15	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
16	E. Ocon	Haas	3	0
17	G. Bortoleto	Audi	2	0
18	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	1	0
19	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	0	0
20	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
21	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
22	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



L. Hamilton

F1 Constructors’ standings

Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	262	6
2	Ferrari	190	1
3	McLaren	141	0
4	Red Bull	89	0
5	Alpine	57	0
6	RB	41	0
7	Haas	21	0
8	Williams	11	0
9	Audi	2	0
10	Aston Martin	1	0
11	Cadillac	0	0



Badminton Men’s ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Shi Yu Qi	1,05,305	12
2	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	92,565	16
3	Anders Antonsen	91,155	17
4	Jonatan Christie	88,431	17
5	Christo Popov	84,682	20
6	Chou Tien Chen	80,280	27
7	Alex Lanier	74,525	17
8	Li Shi Feng	73,083	16
9	Victor Lai	72,915	21
10	Alwi Farhan	70,369	19
11	Kodai Naraoka	68,020	21
12	Lin Chun-Yi	66,594	18
13	Loh Kean Yew	65,700	18
14	Lakshya Sen	65,213	22
15	Weng Hong Yang	59,341	17

Top Indians ▶



Lakshya Sen
Rank 14



Ayush Shetty
Rank 21



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Joe Root	871	932
2	Harry Brook	866	898
3	Travis Head	853	884
4	Steve Smith	831	947
5	Kamindu Mendis	781	784
6	Temba Bavuma	775	806
7	Shubman Gill	743	807
8	Yashasvi Jaiswal	733	858
9	Dinesh Chandimal	717	755
10	Rachin Ravindra	715	737

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Jasprit Bumrah	870	908
2	Matt Henry	870	870
3	Mitchell Starc	838	852
4	Pat Cummins	832	914
5	Marco Jansen	825	825
6	Scott Boland	820	820
7	Noman Ali	817	853
8	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
9	Josh Hazlewood	775	864
10	Nathan Lyon	753	812

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Daryl Mitchell	815	840
2	Shubman Gill	791	841
3	Virat Kohli	768	908
4	Rohit Sharma	754	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	712	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Shai Hope	683	782
8	Harry Tector	679	730
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Brook	656	656

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	682	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
5	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
6	Adil Rashid	629	671
7	Kuldeep Yadav	614	757
8	Mehidy Hasan	604	722
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
10	Mitchell Santner	599	656

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Abhishek Sharma	875	931
2	Ishan Kishan	871	871
3	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
4	Phil Salt	792	881
5	Pathum Nissanka	751	796
6	Tilak Varma	742	845
7	Suryakumar Yadav	722	912
8	Jos Buttler	716	794
9	Mitchell Marsh	706	706
10	Dewald Brevis	702	738

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	753	828
2	Varun Chakravarthi	740	818
3	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
4	Adil Rashid	721	747
5	Jasprit Bumrah	702	783
6	Adam Zampa	700	746
7	Nathan Ellis	675	678
8	Corbin Bosch	669	745
9	Wanindu Hasaranga	668	809
10	Mujeeb Ur Rahman	663	757



P.K. AJITH KUMAR

Bell and Trott lent me their bats; and I said, my gosh, I would like to make a comeback

Dennis Amiss has had a significant influence on cricket's evolution, going where no man had gone before in ODIs and mainstreaming protective headgear. The 83-year-old Englishman talks about living through a game-changing era, appreciating modern cricket, making big hundreds, and being tempted to return when he first wielded a modern bat

INTERVIEW

Dennis Amiss

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Dennis Amiss scored the first ODI hundred in history. He introduced the helmet to cricket. And he had a penchant for turning his hundreds into bigger hundreds (of his 11 Test centuries, eight went past 150). Excerpts from an exclusive interview Amiss gave *The Hindu* at the Edgbaston Golf Club in Birmingham:

How did the idea of wearing a helmet while batting come up?

I first mentioned it to Tony Greig and said, 'Look, you know, we are going to Australia, for Kerry Packer's World Series Cricket. There are 16 bowlers who can all bowl at 90 miles an hour. Having been there with Lillee and Thomson, I think we need a bit of protection. I am at a helmet place at the moment. They might be able to provide us with helmets.' I don't remember how I came to



I was just tooting around and I saw this [motorcycle] helmet place. I told Tony Greig, 'There are 16 bowlers who can bowl at 90 miles an hour [in the Packer series]. We need a bit of protection

be there. But I suddenly thought, my gosh, helmets for cricket!

Nobody had used helmets in cricket before that?

Well, Mike Brearley had his skullcap. But nobody wore a helmet.

So you were riding a bike when you saw this helmet shop?

Yes, I was just tooting around and I saw this helmet place. I went in and inquired. And they said they couldn't specifically make them for cricket, but what they could do, they might adapt what they have got. So, I told Tony and he said he would have a word with Kerry Packer. He had a word with Kerry and Kerry said, 'Bring it on'. He said, 'The more innovation, the better. We are going to play white ball cricket, we are going to play floodlit cricket, we are going to have coloured clothing. Why not helmets?'

So I took three helmets out, one of which I wore and Tony had the other one. And then David Hookes got his jaw broken trying to hook Andy Roberts at Sydney. There were so many fast bowlers. Michael Holding, Andy Roberts, Garth

Le Roux... Holding was the fastest, when he got his rhythm right.

How did the rest of the cricketing world react to the helmet?

I never thought it would take off in this country, but suddenly it did. And I was just amazed. And then we brought the grill out. And so, yeah, it was something I started. It is just amazing how it has all taken off and especially in this country which is very traditional.

How do you look back at your two double hundreds against the West Indies? At Kingston in 1974, England had a deficit of more than 200 and you saved that Test.

Yes, we were facing defeat and we had lost the first Test in Trinidad. So, it was important, really important that we save that one and keep the series alive. We battled through and it was a really good wicket. And I suppose that Keith Boyce was slippery for the first few overs, as quick as anybody. So it was a matter of trying to see Boyce off and then they had Bernard Julien who was a good bowler, and of course Lance Gibbs and Gary Sobers.

The other double hundred came at the Oval in 1976.

I was coming back after being left out and hit on the head early in the series. There were no helmets then. So I ducked into one at Lord's. But anyway, I changed my stance. I went and did a little bit back and across, which Kenny Barrington had done successfully all his career, and that helped me. We had beautiful sunshine and there were good wickets. My coach, Tiger Smith, always said to me, 'Dennis, you will get noughts, lots of low scores, but when



I love short-form cricket. I am fine with all these innovative shots. What does concern me is the short boundaries. These days, with the bats, the ball springs off

you get in, you get 100. Take your guard again and get 150. When you get 150, take your guard again and get 200. And when you get 200 and so on.'

Bishan Bedi helped you play against spin. How did that happen?

Well, we were on the [1972-73] tour of India with Tony Lewis, and you had the four spinners – Bedi, B. Chandrasekhar, Erapalli Prasanna, Venkat-araghavan. And the wickets turned, and we had not come across wickets like that against such great bowlers.

And, you know, it gets in your mind, how do you play them and that sort of thing. We were going to Pakistan afterwards, after the tour. And I was left out for the last Test. Bishan came to me and he said, 'Why were you not batting well? At the beginning of the season, we thought you would be the main batter.' And I said, 'Well, you know, you bowl well at me and you have got me out. The only thing is I can't practise because the nets are in the middle.' He said, 'I will tell you what to do. Leave it with me. And he came back later and said, 'We have to get the net up after the match, tell the players to go home. You put your pads on. Pras, Venkat, and I will bowl at you, but not Chandrasekhar.'

And we played a match. 'Okay, that's two runs. Okay, that's one run. Four. Really good shot. Four. You would have been out there. I think we would have got you out there. So, you are one wicket down. One for 20.' That just gave me confidence. I went to Pakistan. It was very kind of Bish. And I think that he was chastised for that.

Was the decision to play the Packer series a tough one?

It was. It was a difficult time because the Warwickshire committee were entrenched in the England and Wales Cricket Board in London. They took a tough stand. It was only Packer saying that in the end, he would settle his disagreements with Australian cricket. Therefore, 'Test match cricket could resume, as long as all his players he had signed got a contract with their counties.

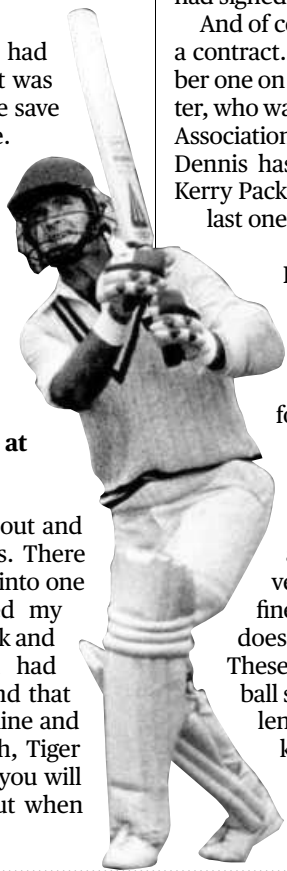
And of course, Warwickshire wouldn't give me a contract. So Richie Benaud, who was his number one on cricket, was in touch with Jack Bannister, who was chairman of the Professional Cricket Association and a Warwickshire player. They said Dennis has got to have a contract. Otherwise, Kerry Packer doesn't make the deal. So I was the last one to sign.

How do you view the innovations in cricket, shots such as the ramp shot?

I think it is wonderful. I love short-form cricket. We played 40 overs.

The John Player Sunday League?

Yes. And we had players like Mushtaq and Hanif Mohammad playing the reverse sweep, before Mike Gatting. I am fine with all these innovative shots. What does concern me is the short boundaries. These days, with the bats, the new bats, the ball springs off. Ian Bell and Jonathan Trott lent me their bats, just to have a little knock in the nets. And I said, my gosh, I would like to make a comeback.



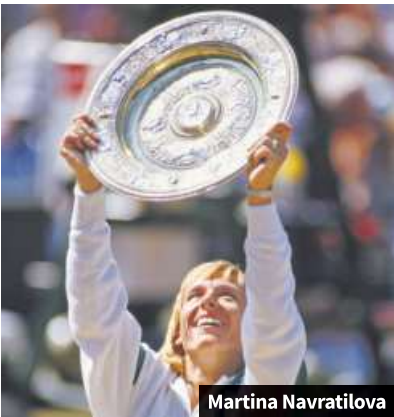
GETTY IMAGES

GAME THEORY

Wimbledon's greatest champions: supreme on grass

Novak Djokovic will be looking to equal Roger Federer's men's record of eight Wimbledon singles titles when the 2026 Championships begin on Monday. The 39-year-old hasn't tasted success at the grass Major since 2022, but has made two finals and a semifinal during this period. We look at the players who have won the most singles titles at Wimbledon. The first men's edition was played in 1877, the first women's event seven years later.

MOST WOMEN'S TITLES		
Player	Titles	Years
Martina Navratilova	9	1978, 1979, 1982, 1983, 1984, 1985, 1986, 1987, 1990
Helen Wills Moody	8	1927, 1928, 1929, 1930, 1932, 1933, 1935, 1938
Dorothea Lambert Chambers	7	1903, 1904, 1906, 1910, 1911, 1913, 1914
Steffi Graf	7	1988, 1989, 1991, 1992, 1993, 1995, 1996
Serena Williams	7	2002, 2003, 2009, 2010, 2012, 2015, 2016
Blanche Bingley	6	1886, 1889, 1894, 1897, 1899, 1900
Suzanne Lenglen	6	1919, 1920, 1921, 1922, 1923, 1925
Billie Jean King	6	1966, 1967, 1968, 1972, 1973, 1975
Charlotte Cooper Sterry	5	1895, 1896, 1898, 1901, 1908
Lottie Dod	5	1887, 1888, 1891, 1892, 1893
Venus Williams	5	2000, 2001, 2005, 2007, 2008
Louise Brough	4	1948, 1949, 1950, 1955
MOST MEN'S TITLES		
Player	Titles	Years
Roger Federer	8	2003, 2004, 2005, 2006, 2007, 2009, 2012, 2017
William Renshaw	7	1881, 1882, 1883, 1884, 1885, 1886, 1889
Pete Sampras	7	1993, 1994, 1995, 1997, 1998, 1999, 2000
Novak Djokovic	7	2011, 2014, 2015, 2018, 2019, 2021, 2022
Laurence Doherty	5	1902, 1903, 1904, 1905, 1906
Bjorn Borg	5	1976, 1977, 1978, 1979, 1980
Reginald Doherty	4	1897, 1898, 1899, 1900
Anthony Wilding	4	1910, 1911, 1912, 1913
Rod Laver	4	1961, 1962, 1968, 1969



Martina Navratilova



Helen Wills



Roger Federer

SOURCE: WIMBLEDON

PICTURE THIS



GETTY IMAGES

The punisher

Shinnecock Hills is one of those golf courses that defy conquests — it simply doesn't want you to win.

The venue for the 2026 US Open, Shinnecock evokes awe among experts, players and golf historians, who look at it

as a timeless, albeit punishing, masterpiece.

This year's edition, won by Wyndham Clark with a score of four-under, featured just three players who finished under par. On the last two occasions the US Open was hosted by Shinnecock, only two players finished under par across both tournaments.

Just why is the links course such a challenge?

Set on sprawling open terrain, lashed by coastal gusts, it is shaped like a vortex that directs golfers into a path of constant wind direction changes as they navigate the holes.

According to those who have played there, Shinne-

cock's fairways create optical illusions off the tee, the canted greens are designed to keep the ball from the putting surfaces and the bunkers are downright malicious.

In addition to taming the course last weekend, Clark also had to master his nerves and overcome a hostile crowd to triumph.